IELTS Academic Skills and Practice

A practical study book for intermediate learners aiming for Band 7

Build clear English. Practise with purpose. Learn from every attempt.

This book develops Speaking, Reading, Writing and Listening through explanations, original examples, sentence patterns, grammar lessons and guided practice. It is designed for a learner who can communicate in everyday English but needs greater accuracy, flexibility and control under exam conditions.

You will learn how to extend a spoken answer, find evidence in a reading passage, follow changes of mind in a recording, describe visual information and develop a convincing essay. Each skill is connected to the language that makes it work.

The book includes original reading practice, a listening mini-test with scripts and audio, complete Writing and Speaking practice tasks, explained answers, a grammar check and an eight-week study programme. Use a separate notebook for longer answers and recordings for speaking practice.

Your goal: make your strongest English available reliably, even when the topic is unfamiliar or time is limited.

Prepared for your IELTS Academic study • October 2026

Independent preparation material created with AI assistance. This is not an official IELTS publication, and its original practice tasks are not calibrated IELTS tests. Model responses illustrate useful techniques; they are not examiner-awarded band scores. Official test information and further resources are referenced at the end.

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A quick route: read pages 3-7, complete your baseline, then study your weakest skill alongside the grammar pages. **A thorough route:** follow the eight-week plan and return to difficult exercises after several days.

How to use this book

Turn a lesson into a skill

Reading an explanation creates familiarity. Using the explanation without looking creates a skill. Work through each lesson in four stages: notice the technique, try it slowly, check what happened, and repeat with a new example. When an exercise is open-ended, compare your answer with the principle being taught rather than expecting identical wording.

For example, after learning a contrast structure, write: “Although online courses are convenient, some students need regular classroom contact.” Then close the book and explain a different contrast aloud. Finally, use the same structure in a paragraph about transport. This transfers knowledge between skills.

Keep three simple records

An error log: record the original error, a corrected version, a short explanation and a fresh example. “People is busy” becomes “People are busy”; the reminder is “people is plural”.

A phrase notebook: store useful combinations such as “meet a deadline”, not isolated words such as “deadline”. Add your own sentence and a note about formality.

A practice record: write the date, task, time, result and next action. “Reading was bad” is not a useful diagnosis. “I chose False when the comparison was missing” gives you something to repair.

Use the models actively

Read a model once for meaning. Next, label what each sentence does: answer, explain, compare, illustrate or qualify. Hide it and write your own response. Copying a whole model does not show whether you can respond to a different prompt.

The listening audio in the companion pack uses a synthetic voice and is intended for these short drills. Use the official audio resources on page 63 for natural accents and full test practice. Do not read the scripts before your first listening attempt.

Try today: choose one notebook, record a one-minute answer about your studies, and write three sentences describing your most common difficulties. These become your starting evidence.

The Academic exam

Know the task before practising

IELTS Academic assesses four skills. Listening has 40 questions across four parts and lasts approximately 30 minutes. Academic Reading has 40 questions across three sections and lasts 60 minutes. Writing lasts 60 minutes and contains two tasks. Speaking is an interview lasting 11-14 minutes. [S1-S5]

In Academic Writing Task 1, describe visual information in at least 150 words. In Task 2, develop a response to an argument, view or problem in at least 250 words. A useful allocation is about 20 minutes for Task 1 and 40 for Task 2; Task 2 has twice the weight. Write connected prose rather than bullet-point answers. [S4]

Speaking moves from familiar questions to a prepared long turn and then a more abstract discussion. Listening and Speaking are shared with General Training, but this book's Reading and Writing preparation is Academic. [S1, S5]

Current delivery guidance

IELTS announced a move away from the fully paper-based test from mid-2026, with implementation dates varying by market. A Writing on Paper option is being introduced in selected markets within computer delivery. Check your centre's booking instructions and practise with the interface you will use. Do not assume that an older book's paper-test transfer timings apply to your booking. [S8]

Practise the mechanics

Use the official computer familiarisation resources. Learn to move between questions, review flagged answers and type accurately while watching the time. In Reading, the 60 minutes includes entering your answers; do not leave a separate transfer stage until after the time expires. [S3]

Preparation task: write down your required overall band and any minimum for each skill. These are separate requirements: an overall 7 does not automatically mean every skill is 7. Confirm the accepted test type directly with your receiving organisation before booking.

Understanding Band 7

Aim for consistent control

An overall band is calculated from the four skill bands and rounded to a whole or half band. An average ending in .25 rounds up to the next half band; .75 rounds up to the next whole band. Listening and Reading answers are marked out of 40. Official guidance gives roughly 30 correct answers as a Band 7 reference for Listening and Academic Reading, but thresholds vary between test versions. [S6]

Do not convert the short exercises in this book into IELTS bands. They are teaching tools, with fewer questions and different difficulty from a full official test.

What productive skills require

Writing considers task fulfilment, organisation, vocabulary, and grammatical range and accuracy. Speaking considers fluency and coherence, vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation. The four criteria within each assessment are equally weighted. [S6]

Band 7 Speaking involves sustaining longer answers, using vocabulary flexibly, paraphrasing when necessary, and producing frequent accurate sentences with both simple and complex grammar. Some errors and hesitation can remain. [S7]

For Writing, a useful interpretation of the Band 7 descriptors is to answer the particular question, maintain a clear position, organise ideas logically and develop relevant support. Vocabulary should convey precise meaning; complex structures need reasonable control. Study the full official descriptors, because a checklist alone cannot reproduce examiner judgement. [S9]

Convert a score aim into behaviour

Instead of “use advanced words”, aim to “choose the exact verb and its usual partners”. Instead of “speak faster”, aim to “finish an explanation without losing the main point”. Instead of “write longer”, aim to “explain why my example supports my claim”.

Self-check: highlight two sentences from your latest essay that directly answer the prompt. Underline one claim that lacks an explanation. Record a correction task for tomorrow. Improvement becomes visible when you measure specific behaviours.

Your starting point

A diagnostic session

Use an unused official Academic Listening and Reading test from the resources on page 63. Follow its instructions, timings and answer key. Record raw scores separately. Do not pause a recording or use a dictionary during the timed attempt. Afterwards, a dictionary and transcript become learning tools.

For Writing, complete the two tasks on page 59 in 60 minutes. Keep the first draft unchanged so that later improvements are visible. For Speaking, ask a partner to use page 26 and record your answers. If alone, read each prompt, look away and answer without restarting the recording.

Diagnose the cause

For every incorrect Reading answer, locate the exact evidence. Mark the cause as vocabulary, misunderstanding, question instructions, unsupported inference or time. For Listening, add sound recognition, spelling and loss of place. A correct answer guessed without evidence deserves review too.

Review Writing in this order: response to the question, development of ideas, paragraph order, sentence accuracy and word choice. Review Speaking by listening first without a transcript. Note where you become hard to follow. Then transcribe thirty seconds and inspect repeated errors.

An example diagnosis

“I got 24 Reading answers right” describes performance. “Four errors came from confusing a missing fact with a contradiction; three came from exceeding the word limit” explains what to practise. Work on these specific weaknesses before taking another complete test.

Do not rely on your own judgement for a precise Writing or Speaking band. A qualified teacher can use the official descriptors and identify patterns that you miss. Automated feedback can help locate possible problems, but check its corrections and treat its score as an estimate.

Write your baseline: Listening __/40; Reading __/40; Writing's main weakness __; Speaking's main weakness __. Choose only two priorities for the next seven days. Keep the remaining weaknesses in your log rather than trying to fix everything at once.

An eight week study plan

A sustainable weekly routine

Aim for five focused study days, one review or test day, and one lighter day each week. A suggested study session is 15 minutes of grammar or vocabulary, 25 minutes on a receptive skill, 25 minutes on a productive skill and 10 minutes reviewing errors. Adjust the workload to your available time; this schedule is a study framework, not a promise of a particular score.

Week 1: complete the baseline. Study sentences, clauses and tenses. Record short Part 1 answers. Practise finding evidence in Reading without rushing.

Week 2: study articles, agreement and collocations. Work on True/False/Not Given. Practise spelling and numbers in Listening. Write Task 1 introductions and overviews.

Week 3: practise a daily Part 2 long turn. Study comparisons, passive forms and relative clauses. Complete a Task 1 report, revise it and write a different report two days later.

Week 4: focus on Task 2 question analysis and paragraph development. Practise Reading headings and Listening distractors. Take one unused timed Reading test and review every uncertain answer.

Week 5: practise Part 3 reasoning. Complete the reading passages and listening mini-test in this book. Use their explanations to identify habits, then test those habits with official materials.

Week 6: complete two timed Writing sessions and two recorded Speaking interviews. Seek feedback on recurring problems. Use new topics when repeating a technique.

Week 7: complete an unused official Listening-Reading-Writing sequence under its stated conditions. Review it the following day. Keep a short list of errors you can realistically reduce.

Week 8: repeat a realistic mock, compare several recent results and rehearse your exam routine. Reduce heavy study immediately before the test. Review familiar language and logistics.

If you have less time: preserve the cycle of attempt, explanation, correction and retest. Completing many tests without reviewing them is a poor substitute for learning from fewer tests carefully.

Building a complete sentence

Find the core

Most statements need a subject and a finite verb: “Students study.” Many verbs also require an object or complement: “Students need feedback.” “The course is demanding.” The finite verb carries tense or works with an auxiliary: “She studies”; “She has studied”; “She can study”.

Start with a clear core, then add information. “The library closes.” Add time: “The library closes at eight.” Add a reason: “The library closes at eight because staff numbers are limited.” Length should follow meaning, not a desire to sound impressive.

Recognise common patterns

Subject + verb: “Demand increased.”

Subject + verb + object: “The council improved transport.”

Subject + linking verb + complement: “Public transport is affordable.”

Subject + verb + indirect object + direct object: “The tutor gave us feedback.” Another form is “The tutor gave feedback to us.”

An introductory phrase is not the main clause. “In many large cities” leaves the reader waiting. Complete it: “In many large cities, housing is expensive.” Similarly, “Because the service was unreliable” needs a main clause: “Because the service was unreliable, commuters used their cars.”

Practise

Correct these fragments or incomplete sentences.

1. Many students in my city very ambitious.

2. Because public transport is cheaper.

3. The new policy gives.

4. Living close to campus convenient.

Possible answers: 1. “Many students in my city are very ambitious.” 2. “I take the bus because public transport is cheaper.” 3. “The new policy gives residents more choice.” 4. “Living close to campus is convenient.”

Transfer task: write three sentences about your home. Circle each subject and underline its finite verb. If you cannot identify the core, simplify the sentence. This habit is especially helpful when editing a long Task 2 sentence under time pressure.

Combining ideas

Choose the relationship first

A simple sentence has one main clause: “The service is cheap.” A compound sentence links main clauses: “The service is cheap, but it is unreliable.” A complex sentence contains a main clause and a subordinate clause: “Although the service is cheap, it is unreliable.” None is automatically better; effective writing uses the form that expresses the intended relationship.

Reason: “Many commuters drive because buses are infrequent.”

Result: “Buses are infrequent, so many commuters drive.”

Contrast: “Although buses are affordable, many commuters drive.”

Condition: “If buses ran more frequently, more people might use them.”

Notice the grammar after different connectors. “Because” introduces a clause: “because fares increased”. “Because of” introduces a noun phrase: “because of higher fares”. “Despite” also takes a noun phrase or an -ing form: “despite the delay”; “despite arriving late”.

Avoid double connectors

Do not write “Although buses are cheap, but people drive.” Use either “Although buses are cheap, people drive” or “Buses are cheap, but people drive”. Likewise, choose “Because it rained, we stayed inside” or “It rained, so we stayed inside”.

Practise

Combine each pair in two different ways.

1. The course is expensive. It provides excellent feedback.

2. The roads were flooded. The deliveries arrived late.

3. The city improves cycle lanes. More residents may cycle.

Possible answers: 1. “Although the course is expensive, it provides excellent feedback.” / “The course is expensive, but it provides excellent feedback.” 2. “Because the roads were flooded, the deliveries arrived late.” / “The deliveries arrived late because of flooding.” 3. “If the city improves cycle lanes, more residents may cycle.” / “Better cycle lanes may encourage more residents to cycle.”

Speaking link: use one reason and one contrast in a response about your neighbourhood. Keep the sentences short enough to say comfortably.

Choosing tenses

Match the time and meaning

Use the present simple for habits and general situations: “I usually study after dinner.” Use the present continuous for an activity in progress or a temporary arrangement: “I am taking an evening course this month.” A time expression helps the listener interpret your choice.

Use the past simple for a finished event at a finished time: “I moved here in 2022.” Use the present perfect for an experience or a situation connected to now: “I have lived here since 2022.” Avoid “I have moved here in 2022” when describing that completed move.

The past continuous gives background: “I was revising when my friend called.” The past perfect places one past event before another: “The class had started by the time I arrived.” Use it when that earlier relationship matters, rather than adding it to every narrative.

Apply tense to the task

In Task 1, a chart showing 2010-2020 usually needs past forms. A process with no historical date often needs the present simple. Forecast data can use “is projected to”, which distinguishes a prediction from an observed result. In Speaking, switch tenses naturally when moving from past experience to present opinion.

Practise

Choose the appropriate form.

1. I live / have lived here since childhood.

2. Last year, the number rises / rose to 500.

3. At the moment, I prepare / am preparing for IELTS.

4. By the time we reached the station, the train left / had left.

5. The diagram shows how glass is recycled / was recycled, with no past date given.

Answers: 1. have lived; 2. rose; 3. am preparing; 4. had left; 5. is recycled.

Transfer task: answer “How has your area changed?” using one sentence about the past, one about a change up to now and one about the present. Example: “There were fewer apartments when I was young. Several new blocks have been built. The area now feels much busier.”

Articles and countability

Decide what kind of noun you have

A singular countable noun usually needs a determiner: “a student”, “the student”, “my student”. An uncountable noun does not normally take “a”: “useful advice”, not “a useful advice”. Common IELTS-related uncountable nouns include information, equipment, research, traffic and accommodation.

Use “a” or “an” when introducing one non-specific countable item: “The city needs a hospital.” Choose by sound: “an hour”, but “a university”. Use “the” when the reader can identify the particular item: “The hospital near the station is being expanded.”

For a general category, plural or uncountable nouns often take no article: “Libraries support education.” “Public transport reduces congestion.” For a specific group, use “the”: “The libraries in this survey stayed open late.”

Measure uncountable nouns

Use “a piece of advice”, “two items of equipment” or “several research projects”. Choose a natural unit, not an invented plural. “Researches” is not the usual plural noun for research studies in this context.

Practise

Correct the errors.

1. My teacher gave me an advice.

2. University needs new equipments.

3. The education is important for everyone. [Education in general]

4. I bought a umbrella near station. [A particular local station]

5. There are many traffic in the centre.

Answers: 1. “My teacher gave me some advice.” 2. “The university needs new equipment.” 3. “Education is important for everyone.” 4. “I bought an umbrella near the station.” 5. “There is a lot of traffic in the centre.”

Editing routine: check singular countable nouns first. Then check the uncountable nouns you repeatedly misuse. Finally, ask whether every “the” points to something identifiable. Do not delete all articles in an attempt to avoid errors; articles carry meaning and help a reader follow your argument.

Agreement and verb patterns

Let the subject control the verb

“The number of students is increasing” has the singular subject “number”. “A number of students are absent” means several students, so the verb is plural. Words between the subject and verb can distract you: “The quality of the facilities has improved.” The core is “quality has improved”.

After “each” and “every” with a singular noun, use a singular verb: “Each student receives feedback.” “People” normally takes a plural verb: “People need reliable transport.” In formal writing, match “there is” to a singular noun and “there are” to a plural noun.

Learn the pattern with the verb

Some verbs take an -ing form: “enjoy reading”, “avoid driving”, “consider moving”. Others take an infinitive: “decide to study”, “hope to improve”, “plan to apply”. After a preposition, use a noun or -ing form: “interested in learning”; “good at explaining”.

Compare “allow people to work” with “let people work”. Compare “suggest studying earlier” with “suggest that students study earlier”. Avoid “suggest students to study”. Correct patterns are usually more valuable than rare vocabulary.

Practise

1. The number of applicants has / have doubled.

2. Each of the rooms needs / need cleaning.

3. I enjoy to read / reading biographies.

4. The course allows me improve / to improve my writing.

5. We discussed about the problem / the problem.

6. I look forward to hear / hearing from you.

Answers: 1. has; 2. needs; 3. reading; 4. to improve; 5. the problem; 6. hearing. In number 6, “to” is a preposition within “look forward to”, not an infinitive marker.

Transfer task: write a short paragraph about study habits using “enjoy”, “plan”, “avoid” and “allow”. Read it aloud and check both the main verb and the verb that follows it. Store the complete patterns in your vocabulary notebook.

Modals and conditions

Show strength and uncertainty

Modal verbs change the force of a statement. “The policy will reduce traffic” is a strong prediction. “The policy may reduce traffic” allows uncertainty. “The policy could reduce traffic if fares remain affordable” adds a condition. Choose the strength your reasoning supports.

For recommendations, “should” is usually less forceful than “must”. “Schools should provide guidance” proposes a useful action. “Drivers must follow traffic laws” describes an obligation. Do not use “must” merely because you want a sentence to sound confident.

Build conditional meanings

General relationship: “If water freezes, it expands.”

Real future possibility: “If I practise regularly, I will become more confident.”

Imagined present or future: “If public transport were cheaper, more people might use it.”

Imagined alternative past: “If I had planned my essay, I would have organised it better.”

Avoid adding “will” to the ordinary if-clause in a first conditional: “If the council will improve buses” should normally be “If the council improves buses”. Modal verbs are followed by the base form: “might increase”, not “might increases”.

Practise

Repair these sentences.

1. If fees will rise, fewer students may enrol.

2. The government should to invest in training.

3. This change might improves safety.

4. If I had more time yesterday, I would have checked my answer.

Answers: 1. “If fees rise, fewer students may enrol.” 2. “The government should invest in training.” 3. “This change might improve safety.” 4. “If I had had more time yesterday, I would have checked my answer.”

Task 2 application: take a sweeping claim such as “Technology solves educational problems”. Rewrite it with a realistic condition: “Technology can improve access to education if students have reliable internet and appropriate support.” The revised sentence gives you something specific to explain in the paragraph.

Relative clauses and passive voice

Add information without starting again

A defining relative clause identifies the noun: “Students who work full time may need flexible classes.” Without the clause, the claim refers to all students. A non-defining clause adds extra information: “The central library, which opened in 1998, now offers evening classes.” Use commas around this extra information.

Use “who” for people and “which” for things. “That” can introduce many defining clauses but does not replace “which” in an ordinary non-defining clause. Avoid repeating the subject: “The teacher who she helped me” should be “The teacher who helped me”.

Focus on an action or result

The passive uses a form of “be” plus a past participle: “The bottles are washed”; “The bridge was built”; “The park has been expanded”. It is useful when the actor is unknown, obvious or less important than the action.

Task 1 processes often use passive forms because the material is the focus: “The paper is sorted before it is pulped.” Active voice is clearer when the actor matters: “Residents sort their waste at home.” Do not make every sentence passive simply to sound academic.

Practise

Combine or transform the sentences.

1. The students need extra support. They joined the course late.

2. Workers inspect the containers. [Focus on containers]

3. The city opened the museum in 2005. [Focus on museum]

4. My local park is being renovated. It is beside the river. [Add location as extra information]

Answers: 1. “The students who joined the course late need extra support.” 2. “The containers are inspected.” 3. “The museum was opened in 2005.” 4. “My local park, which is beside the river, is being renovated.”

Editing check: after writing a passive, check the participle and the time. “Was build” needs “was built”. After writing a relative clause, check that the reader can identify the noun it describes without confusion.

Comparisons and quantities

Compare like with like

“Rail travel was more popular than bus travel” compares modes. “The proportion using rail was higher than the proportion using buses” compares proportions. Avoid “Rail was higher than buses” when your actual measurement is the percentage of travellers.

Use “twice as high as”, not “twice higher than”, when you want an unambiguous two-to-one comparison. If A is 40 and B is 20, A is twice B. A is 100% higher than B, while the difference between shares of 40% and 20% is 20 percentage points.

Describe amount accurately

Use “fewer” with plural countable nouns: “fewer cars”. Use “less” with uncountable quantities: “less traffic”. Use “number” for countable items and “amount” for uncountable ones: “the number of vehicles”; “the amount of fuel”.

“Most” means more than half. “The largest share” may be less than half when several categories exist. If categories are 40%, 35% and 25%, the first is the largest, but it is not a majority. “Approximately” signals a rounded or estimated figure, not uncertainty about what the chart says.

Practise

Use these figures: walking 15%, cycling 30%, bus 40%, car 15%.

1. Write a sentence comparing cycling with walking.

2. Describe the largest category without calling it a majority.

3. Combine the equal categories.

4. Explain the difference between the bus and cycling figures.

Possible answers: 1. “The cycling share was twice the walking share.” 2. “Bus travel accounted for the largest proportion, at 40%.” 3. “Walking and car travel each represented 15%.” 4. “The bus share exceeded the cycling share by 10 percentage points.”

Task 1 habit: before writing a comparison, identify the unit, the categories and the date. A grammatically elegant sentence still fails if it compares the wrong measurements or invents a trend between dates that are not shown.

Punctuation and editing

Make the boundaries visible

A full stop ends a complete sentence. A comma cannot normally join two complete sentences on its own: “The city is crowded, housing is expensive” is a comma splice. Repair it with a full stop, a conjunction or a semicolon: “The city is crowded, and housing is expensive.”

Use a comma after an introductory subordinate clause: “Although the scheme is expensive, it may reduce congestion.” When the clause follows, a comma is often unnecessary: “The scheme may reduce congestion because it improves bus frequency.” Punctuation should make the relationship easier to read.

Avoid decorative complexity

A semicolon links closely related main clauses: “Demand increased; capacity remained unchanged.” You do not need semicolons to achieve good writing. If you are uncertain, two correct sentences are preferable to a confusing chain of clauses.

An apostrophe can show possession: “a student's essay”; “the students' essays”. It does not create an ordinary plural: “many idea's” should be “many ideas”. “Its” is possessive; “it's” means “it is” or “it has”.

Practise

Correct these examples.

1. The policy is useful, it needs better funding.

2. Although the town is small it has several colleges.

3. The company changed it's policy.

4. Many student's prefer online lessons. [Students generally]

Answers: 1. “The policy is useful, but it needs better funding.” 2. “Although the town is small, it has several colleges.” 3. “The company changed its policy.” 4. “Many students prefer online lessons.”

A final two-minute scan: look for missing verbs, sentence boundaries, singular subjects with plural verbs, articles before singular countable nouns and mistakes you have logged before. Read the sentence immediately before and after a correction; a local change can create a new inconsistency. When time is short, repair errors that affect meaning before polishing minor stylistic details.

Learning vocabulary that you can use

Store a word with its partners

Knowing a translation is only a beginning. For each useful item, learn its meaning, grammar, pronunciation, common partners and level of formality. Record “provide access to education”, “a significant increase in demand” and “take responsibility for a task”. These combinations are easier to reuse than isolated nouns.

Create a notebook entry such as: **reliable**, adjective; meaning “able to be trusted or depended on”; partners “reliable information”, “reliable transport”; example “Reliable buses would make commuting less stressful”. Add a personal spoken example and a more formal written one.

Paraphrase the idea

Original: “Many students cannot afford university fees.” Possible paraphrase: “The cost of university prevents some students from enrolling.” This changes structure while preserving the main meaning. It also changes “many” to “some”, so it weakens the quantity: that may be acceptable in a general discussion, but it would be inaccurate if you were reporting exact source information.

In Reading, paraphrase recognition helps you match “a fall in demand” with “fewer people wanted the service”. In Writing, do not replace every word mechanically. “Children” does not always mean “youngsters”, and a “problem” is not always a “crisis”.

Retrieval practice

Review five useful phrases after one day, three days and a week. Cover the examples and make new sentences. Then use two phrases in a spoken answer and two in a paragraph. If you repeatedly misuse one phrase, simplify it and check a reliable learner's dictionary.

Practice: replace the vague words: “The policy is good because it does good things for poor people.” One precise version is: “The policy could help low-income families by reducing their transport costs.”

Personal task: choose six phrases from something you read this week. Keep only phrases relevant to topics you discuss. Write why each phrase is useful; vocabulary selection should serve communication rather than fill a long list.

Topic vocabulary in context

Education and work

Develop practical skills: “Group projects help students develop practical skills such as negotiation.” **Receive constructive feedback:** “I improve more quickly when I receive constructive feedback.” **Maintain a work-life balance:** “Flexible hours can help employees maintain a work-life balance.”

Avoid vague praise. Explain which skill improves, what the feedback changes, or how flexibility helps. In a spoken answer, a personal example often supplies that detail naturally.

Cities and the environment

Affordable housing: “Young workers may move away if affordable housing is unavailable.” **Public transport network:** “A reliable public transport network can connect outer districts with employment centres.” **Reduce household waste:** “Repair services may help residents reduce household waste.”

Do not treat all environmental words as synonyms. Pollution concerns harmful contamination; congestion concerns crowding, especially traffic. A policy can reduce congestion without eliminating pollution.

Technology and society

Protect personal data: “Users need clear information about how companies protect personal data.” **Unequal access:** “Online services may create difficulties for people with unequal access to reliable internet.” **Face-to-face interaction:** “Video calls are convenient, but I still value face-to-face interaction.”

Health and daily life

A balanced diet: “Preparing meals at home helps me maintain a balanced diet.” **Regular physical activity:** “Parks give residents more opportunities for regular physical activity.” **Access to services:** “Rural residents may travel long distances to access specialist services.” These are language examples, not medical recommendations.

Practise across skills

Choose one phrase from each topic. First, give a twenty-second personal answer using it. Next, write a formal sentence about a wider social issue. Finally, underline the words you must keep together, such as “access to” or “responsibility for”.

Challenge: qualify two claims with “may”, “can” or a condition. “Online education benefits everyone” becomes “Online education can benefit learners who have suitable equipment and enough support.” Precision improves both the argument and the language.

Speaking with a purpose

Answer the question you hear

The examiner wants to understand your meaning across an interview, not hear a memorised speech. Listen for the time and focus of each question. “Did you enjoy science at school?” invites a past experience. “Do you think science is important?” invites a present opinion. Related vocabulary does not make those questions identical.

Use a simple development path: answer directly, add a reason and give a relevant detail. You do not need all three every time. A short factual question may need a brief answer; a broad question can support more explanation.

Three parts with different jobs

Part 1 lasts around 4-5 minutes and concerns familiar subjects. Part 2 includes one minute to prepare a talk lasting up to two minutes, followed by possible brief questions. Part 3 lasts around 4-5 minutes and explores broader ideas connected with the Part 2 topic. [S5]

For Part 1, use ordinary experience. For Part 2, organise a small narrative or description. For Part 3, explain relationships, compare groups, consider conditions and give reasons. Avoid turning every Part 3 answer back into a story about yourself.

Practise in two modes

In learning mode, pause to correct an error and try the sentence again. In simulation mode, keep going as you would in an interview. Review afterwards. If you stop and restart every practice answer, you may improve polished openings without learning how to recover mid-answer.

Record this: “What do you enjoy about the place where you live?” Speak for about thirty seconds. Listen for a direct answer, one clear reason and a specific detail. Then answer again with different wording. Do not memorise the first recording.

Useful reflection: could another person summarise your main point in one sentence? If not, simplify the structure before adding vocabulary. A clear answer with accurate everyday language is a stronger foundation than a long answer whose purpose is difficult to follow.

Part 1 answers that develop naturally

Start small and add meaning

Question: “Do you enjoy cooking?” Weak development: “Yes. Cooking is good. I like it.” Stronger development: “Yes, especially at weekends, because I have time to try something new. Last Sunday, I made a vegetable curry, and it turned out better than I expected.” The second answer adds a reason and a concrete event without becoming a speech.

Question: “How do you usually travel to work or college?” Model: “I normally take the bus because parking near my college is difficult. The journey takes about half an hour, so I often listen to a podcast on the way.” Notice the present simple for the routine.

Question: “Has your routine changed recently?” Model: “Yes, I have started studying earlier in the morning. I used to work late at night, but I found it difficult to concentrate after a long day.” Notice the movement from recent change to past habit.

Useful patterns

Preference: “I tend to prefer X because…”

Frequency: “Most weekdays, I…, although at weekends…”

Change: “I used to…, but these days…”

Qualification: “It depends on…, but generally…”

These are flexible structures, not scripts. Do not begin every answer with the same phrase. Avoid repeating the full question when a direct answer is more natural.

Your turn

Answer four questions: What do you study or do for work? What do you enjoy about it? Do you prefer studying alone? What skill would you like to learn?

For each answer, use one specific detail: a time, place, reason, example or comparison. Record all four without stopping. On replay, count repeated fillers such as “actually” or “you know”; do not try to remove every natural pause.

Repair target: if an answer is only one sentence, add a useful explanation. If it wanders through several unrelated points, retain the strongest two sentences and practise a clearer version.

Planning Part 2 in one minute

Use notes as a route

A cue card gives you a topic and prompts. Use the preparation minute to decide what you will talk about and the order of your points. Notes should contain triggers, not complete sentences. Writing a script wastes time and can make delivery stiff.

Practice card: **Describe a useful skill you learned.** Say what it was, when you learned it, who or what helped you, and explain why it has been useful.

Possible notes: “cooking / first year away / sister video calls / burnt rice / weekly practice / cheaper / friends dinner”. These words create a route from situation to difficulty, improvement and value. They do not lock you into particular wording.

Extend through detail

If you finish early, expand a relevant moment. What was difficult? How did you respond? What changed? How did you feel afterwards? A short incident can supply more meaningful language than listing several unrelated benefits.

Use time signals sparingly: “At first…”, “After a few weeks…”, “Since then…”. Connect the events with reasons and consequences. “I kept practising because…” is more informative than another “and then”.

Practise the preparation minute

Spend roughly the first ten seconds choosing a workable example. Use the next thirty seconds to note a sequence. Use the final twenty seconds to add one specific incident and a closing thought. These are training suggestions, not official sub-timings.

Speak for up to two minutes. If you stop after forty seconds, do not simply speak more slowly; add an explanation or episode. If you exceed two minutes in practice, shorten your opening and remove background that does not serve the topic.

Your turn: prepare the same card for a different skill, such as using a spreadsheet, swimming or repairing a bicycle. Keep the route but change the content. This demonstrates flexible organisation rather than memorisation. Compare your two recordings: which details helped you continue naturally?

A Part 2 model and commentary

Describe a useful skill you learned

“I'd like to talk about learning to cook simple meals, which became important when I moved away from home for college. Before that, I could make tea and perhaps an omelette, but I couldn't really prepare a proper dinner.

“My older sister helped me. We used to have a video call on Sunday evenings, and she would explain one straightforward recipe. The first thing we tried was rice with vegetables. It sounds easy, but I managed to burn the rice because I left the heat too high. She laughed, then showed me how to check it without lifting the lid every few seconds.

“After that, I practised the same few dishes instead of attempting something new every day. That made a difference because I started to understand the process rather than just follow instructions. Within a couple of months, I could put together a meal from whatever was in the kitchen.

“The skill has been useful mainly because it gives me more independence. I spend less on takeaway food, and I don't have to wait for someone else to cook. It has also become a social activity. A few weeks ago, I invited two classmates over and made dinner for them. The food wasn't particularly impressive, but it felt good to share something I'd prepared myself.”

What to notice

The response identifies the skill immediately, establishes a past situation, develops one small failure and explains present value. “Which became important” adds information; “because” explains a cause; “has been useful” links the learning to the present. The final example supports the claim about social value.

This is an illustrative response, not a guaranteed two-minute script or an awarded Band 7 answer. Delivery speed, pronunciation, spontaneity and the rest of the interview also matter.

Transform it: replace cooking with a skill you genuinely know. Keep the movement from need to difficulty to improvement to usefulness, but invent no impressive achievement simply to sound advanced. Record your own version and check whether the useful details fit your chosen skill.

Developing Part 3 answers

Move from experience to explanation

Question: “Why do some adults find it difficult to learn new skills?” A developed answer might be: “One reason is that adults often have less uninterrupted time. Someone working full time may have only short periods available, which makes regular practice difficult. Confidence can also be an issue, especially if they expect to learn as quickly as they did at school.”

The answer identifies causes and explains mechanisms. It does not claim that all adults struggle or that age alone determines learning ability.

Add a qualification

Question: “Should employers pay for staff training?” Model: “In many cases, yes, particularly when the training directly improves someone's work. It seems reasonable for a company to fund a course on equipment its staff must use. However, if the course is mainly for a personal interest, sharing the cost might be more appropriate.”

Useful routes include **claim > reason > example**, **comparison > explanation > exception**, and **prediction > condition > possible consequence**. Choose one route per answer rather than trying to include every possible argument.

Avoid empty generalisations

“Technology is very important in modern society” does not explain much. A more useful point is: “Video tutorials let learners repeat a demonstration at their own pace.” Ask yourself “How?” and “For whom?” to make an abstract answer concrete.

Practice questions

1. Is practical experience more valuable than classroom learning?

2. How might education change over the next twenty years?

3. Why do some people prefer learning in groups?

4. Should governments support adult education?

Give each answer enough development to make your reasoning clear, without forcing a fixed length. In one answer, compare two groups. In another, include a condition. In a third, acknowledge an exception.

Review: underline unsupported words such as “everyone”, “always” and “never” in a transcript. Replace them only when the claim is too broad. Strong opinions are acceptable; the point is to express exactly what you mean and explain it.

Pronunciation that supports meaning

Aim to be understood comfortably

Clear pronunciation involves sounds, word stress, sentence stress, rhythm and intonation. You do not need to imitate a particular national accent. Work first on features that cause a listener to misunderstand your words or lose your meaning.

Compare “I wanted the BLUE one” with “I WANTED the blue one”. Stress changes the emphasis. Practise saying “I usually study in the evening” while emphasising “usually”, then “I”, then “evening”. Explain what contrast each version suggests.

Divide speech into meaningful groups

Mark pauses with a slash: “Although the course was demanding / I enjoyed it / because the feedback was useful.” Avoid pausing inside a close grammatical group such as “because the” or “a useful”. Thought groups help the listener follow the sentence and give you space to breathe.

For word stress, check a learner's dictionary with audio. Listen, repeat, then use the word in a sentence. Practise troublesome pairs in context: “thirteen students” and “thirty students”; “a live discussion” and “I live nearby”. The same spelling can have different pronunciations and meanings.

A short practice cycle

Choose twenty seconds of clear natural speech with a transcript. Listen for meaning. Mark stressed words and pauses. Repeat a short phrase immediately after the speaker, then record yourself saying the whole extract. Finally, speak about your own life using the rhythm you noticed. The final step prevents imitation from becoming the only skill you practise.

Check endings: record “She works”, “They worked” and “Several students attended”. Missing endings can obscure grammar. Practise them within phrases rather than exaggerating each final consonant unnaturally.

Partner task: read five sentences without showing the text. Ask your partner to write what they hear. Focus on the words they misunderstood. This produces more useful feedback than asking whether your accent sounds “good”. Repeat the test after a few days with new sentences containing the same sounds.

Fluency and recovering from mistakes

Keep the meaning moving

Fluency does not mean speaking without any pauses. It means sustaining understandable speech without repeated breakdowns. Give yourself a short moment to think, then begin with a clear point. A brief “Let me think” can be natural; several rehearsed fillers before every answer can become distracting.

If you forget a word, describe it. “I can't remember the exact term, but it's the device that measures how far you've walked.” This demonstrates paraphrase and allows the answer to continue. Do not abandon an otherwise useful example because one noun is missing.

Repair selectively

If a mistake changes your meaning, correct it briefly: “It happened last month - sorry, last year.” If you notice a small grammatical slip, a quick correction is fine, but restarting the entire answer may damage coherence more than the original slip. Practise returning to the main point after a repair.

Reduce avoidable hesitation

Try a three-round exercise. Answer the same broad question for sixty seconds, then forty-five seconds, then thirty seconds. Retain the main idea and one useful example. This is a training drill for organisation, not a test requirement or a reason to rush in the actual interview.

Next, answer a new question using the same structure. If the second topic causes a complete breakdown, you may have memorised content rather than learned a flexible way to organise it.

Practice prompts

Describe a place where you concentrate well. Explain a change you would make to your daily routine. Discuss whether people have enough free time. In each answer, deliberately practise one recovery: paraphrase a forgotten word, correct a date, or return from a brief digression.

Review: listen once for meaning and once for language. Write only three priorities: one organisation issue, one repeated grammar error and one pronunciation issue. Trying to monitor every feature while speaking can make you less fluent. Repair a few recurring problems through focused practice, then let the next recorded interview show what remains.

Speaking practice test one

Run the interview

Ask a partner to read the questions naturally and move on without coaching you. Record the whole session. Use the approximate part timings from page 19. If practising alone, use a timer and avoid reading prepared answers. This is an original practice interview, not a prediction of future exam questions.

Part 1

Work or study: What do you study or do for work? Why did you choose it? Which part do you find most interesting? Is there anything you would like to change?

Your home: What do you like about your home? Where do you usually study? Would you like to live somewhere different in the future?

Reading: What kinds of things do you read? Did you enjoy reading as a child? Do you prefer reading on paper or on a screen?

Part 2

Describe a place where you learned something important.

Say where the place was, when you went there, what you learned, and explain why the experience was important to you.

Prepare for one minute. Speak for up to two minutes. Possible follow-up: Would you like to return to that place?

Part 3

How important is the physical environment for learning? What can museums teach people that schools may not? Do people learn more effectively alone or with others? Should public learning spaces be free? How could cities encourage people to keep learning throughout their lives?

Review without inventing a band

Coherence: identify one answer with a clear beginning and development, and one that loses focus. **Vocabulary:** find one successful paraphrase and one imprecise word. **Grammar:** list repeated errors rather than every isolated slip. **Pronunciation:** note any words a listener needed repeated.

Choose the weakest answer and record a revised version. On the following day, answer a different question that needs the same skill. Keep both recordings. Improvement should appear in new answers, not only in a response you have rehearsed several times.

A reading workflow

Change speed to match the job

Skimming gives you the topic and structure. Scanning locates a name, date or distinctive concept. Close reading establishes the exact meaning around a possible answer. You need all three. Reading every word slowly from the beginning can leave too little time; searching for keywords without reading the surrounding sentence can produce wrong answers.

Start by identifying the question type and instructions. Briefly map the passage: what is each paragraph doing? Then locate evidence for a question, read that area carefully and check the answer against the whole statement. Mark uncertainty and move on when a single item is consuming too much time.

Build a passage map

For a five-paragraph text, notes might be: A problem; B earlier attempt; C new method; D trial results; E limitations. These labels are more useful than copying the first sentence. They help you return to the paragraph likely to contain a reason, comparison or criticism.

Understand paraphrase

Question wording: “The method was too expensive to expand.” Passage wording: “Its cost prevented wider adoption.” The meaning matches without identical vocabulary. Conversely, seeing the same word in both places does not guarantee that the whole claim matches.

Some question types follow passage order; others require you to search across paragraphs. Do not assume a universal order rule. Summary and diagram answers, for example, may not follow the text sequence. [S3]

Practise a manageable timing strategy

For a full official test, begin with an approximate twenty-minute budget per section and adjust after reviewing your performance. You may choose to spend less time on the earlier section and more on a harder later one. Keep enough time to enter and review answers within the 60 minutes.

Review task: after any timed passage, return untimed and justify every answer with a quotation or precise location. If you still cannot explain a correct answer, mark it as a learning gap. Speed improves when the underlying decisions become more accurate and familiar.

True False Not Given

Test the whole statement

True: the passage supports the statement. **False:** the passage supports an incompatible claim. **Not Given:** the passage does not provide enough information to decide. Do not use background knowledge to fill a gap. For Yes/No/Not Given questions, follow the requested labels and evaluate the writer's views or claims. [S3]

Mini-text: “The library extended its weekday opening hours in May. Weekend hours remained unchanged. The manager said the change would be reviewed after six months.”

1. The library began opening longer on weekdays in May. **True:** this restates the first sentence.

2. The library extended its weekend opening hours. **False:** those hours did not change.

3. Most users supported the change. **Not Given:** no survey or user opinion appears.

4. The change was permanent. **Not Given:** a planned review does not by itself prove either permanence or a temporary end date.

Watch scope and comparisons

Words such as “all”, “only”, “mainly”, “before” and “more” can change a claim. If a passage says two methods were used, a statement that only one was used is contradicted. If the passage mentions one method but says nothing about alternatives, exclusivity may be missing rather than contradicted.

Practise

Text: “Forty volunteers joined the pilot. They received online instructions, and twelve also attended a workshop. The researchers did not measure changes in income.”

A. Some volunteers attended a workshop.

B. All volunteers attended a workshop.

C. The workshop participants improved more quickly.

D. The study measured participants' income changes.

Answers: A True; B False; C Not Given; D False. For C, a workshop is mentioned, but its comparative effect is absent. For D, the text explicitly says the measurement did not occur.

Decision habit: ask “Where is the support?” and then “Where is the contradiction?” If neither exists after checking the relevant section, Not Given may be appropriate. “I did not find it quickly” is not sufficient evidence on its own.

Matching headings

Identify the paragraph's main job

A heading summarises the central idea. It should cover most of the paragraph, not merely one striking detail. Read the opening and closing sentences, then check how the middle develops them. Ask: why did the writer include this paragraph?

Mini-paragraph: “A town introduced a bicycle-sharing scheme in 2018. At first, stations were concentrated in the centre, which made the scheme convenient for visitors but less useful for residents in outer districts. The council later moved some stations closer to housing and railway stops. Usage increased after the change.”

Possible headings: i The history of bicycle design; ii Improving the location of a service; iii The dangers of cycling; iv A successful advertising campaign.

Answer: ii. The paragraph explains a location problem and its correction. The date is background, and increased use is the outcome. Neither becomes the main topic by itself.

Handle similar headings

If two headings both mention research, identify the difference: a heading about the reason for a study differs from one about its unexpected results. Briefly label the paragraph in your own words before selecting a heading. This reduces the influence of attractive wording in the options.

For official heading tasks, unused options are normal. Follow the instructions about which paragraphs need headings. Do not force every option into the passage. [S3]

Practise

Paragraph: “The training programme was initially offered only online. However, interviews showed that some participants lacked suitable devices, while others needed help getting started. Organisers therefore added a weekly in-person session and loaned tablets to those who needed them.”

Choose: A Measuring long-term success; B Adapting a programme to users' needs; C Replacing all digital teaching; D Selecting more experienced participants.

Answer: B. The paragraph centres on responding to barriers. C is too strong because the online programme is supplemented, not completely replaced.

Review habit: for every rejected heading, state why it fails: too narrow, too broad, wrong relationship or absent information. This teaches discrimination more effectively than remembering only the correct letter.

Completion questions

Read the limit and predict the grammar

A completion task may ask for words from the passage or choices from a list. Follow that specific instruction. If the instruction says “ONE WORD ONLY”, adding an article can make an otherwise relevant answer invalid. Copy spelling carefully and check whether the gap requires a noun, verb, adjective or number.

Example text: “The roof collects rainwater, which is stored in an underground tank before being used in the garden.”

Summary: “Rainwater is kept in a 1 ____ beneath the ground and is later used in the 2 ____.”
Instruction: ONE WORD ONLY from the text.

Answers: 1 tank; 2 garden. “Underground tank” exceeds the limit, and “storage container” is not the wording requested from the text.

Use grammar as a check

“The main advantage was lower ____” probably needs a plural or uncountable noun. “The system was ____ to install” probably needs an adjective. Prediction narrows your attention, but the passage must still determine the answer. Never insert a plausible word that is not supported.

Practise

Text: “The team replaced plastic trays with wooden boxes. Each box contained six seedlings. Volunteers watered them twice a week, while a technician checked the temperature every morning.”

Use ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER from the text.

1. The new containers were ____ boxes.

2. Each container held ____ seedlings.

3. A ____ monitored the temperature.

4. Watering happened ____ a week.

Answers: 1 wooden; 2 six / 6; 3 technician; 4 twice. The adjective "wooden" fits before "boxes". "Technician" identifies the person responsible, while "twice" expresses frequency.

Check your own practice materials: if a suggested answer breaks the word limit or makes the completed sentence ungrammatical, inspect the wording carefully. Informal practice sets can contain errors. Page 70 demonstrates how to evaluate and repair one such item from your supplied question bank. During an official test, follow the actual instructions and choose the supported answer rather than rewriting the question.

Multiple choice and matching

Match the meaning of the option

In multiple choice, read the stem before the options. Identify whether it asks for a reason, conclusion, opinion, detail or overall purpose. Then locate the relevant evidence. An option can repeat passage words and still answer the wrong question.

Mini-text: “The researchers expected the new signs to reduce waiting times. Waiting times changed little, but visitors asked staff for directions less often. The researchers concluded that the signs had improved navigation rather than service speed.”

Question: What was the main observed benefit? A Shorter queues; B Easier navigation; C More staff; D Lower running costs.

Answer: B. A describes the expectation, not the result. C and D are unsupported. Separating prediction, finding and interpretation is especially useful in academic texts.

Match people to views

For matching features, create a small map: researcher > claim; year > event; place > characteristic. Keep the speaker or source attached to the idea. A writer may report a view and then criticise it, so do not assume every opinion in a passage belongs to the author.

For matching information to paragraphs, search for the requested detail rather than the paragraph's main idea. A paragraph headed “Early difficulties” might contain a brief cost comparison that answers a matching-information question.

Practise

Text: “Mira argued that longer opening hours would attract commuters. Leon preferred improving the online catalogue because people struggled to find resources. Sana believed staff training should come first, since users often needed help evaluating information.”

Match each proposal to Mira, Leon or Sana: 1 Improve search tools; 2 Develop employees' skills; 3 Make access possible later in the day.

Answers: 1 Leon; 2 Sana; 3 Mira. “Catalogue” is paraphrased as “search tools”, and “longer opening hours” as later access.

Timing habit: eliminate options for a reason, not a feeling. If two remain, compare their scope and relationship with the evidence. Record the exact difference during review so you can recognise similar distractors in future passages.

Reading passage one

The neighbourhood repair library

Original teaching passage. Suggested time for this passage and its questions: 15 minutes. This shorter exercise does not represent a full IELTS Reading section.

A When the fictional town of Bellford opened a repair library, its organisers did not intend to compete with local repair businesses. Their aim was to lend tools and teach residents how to maintain ordinary household objects. The idea grew from a survey in which residents said they often replaced simple items because buying the equipment needed for a repair seemed wasteful. A small room in the public library became the project's first home.

B Membership was free, but borrowing required a short introduction to safety procedures. Volunteers checked tools before and after each loan. The library initially stocked equipment for basic furniture and bicycle repairs. Electrical appliances were excluded because the organisers lacked the expertise and insurance needed to supervise that work. Users who brought electrical items were directed to qualified businesses nearby.

C The organisers expected weekend borrowing to dominate. Instead, the busiest collection period was Thursday evening, when people collected tools for projects they planned to begin over the following days. In response, the library extended Thursday opening by two hours. It did not increase its weekend hours. During the first six months, the number of registered members rose steadily, although many members borrowed only once.

D Workshops became an important part of the programme. At first, a volunteer demonstrated a repair while participants watched. Feedback suggested that people enjoyed the demonstrations but were not confident enough to repeat the procedures at home. Organisers therefore introduced smaller sessions in which participants completed a simple repair themselves. These sessions required more volunteers, but participants reported greater confidence afterwards. The project did not measure whether that confidence led to more successful repairs outside the workshops.

E A local shop supplied replacement screws and other small parts at a discount. This arrangement reduced the library's running costs while bringing the shop customers who needed materials for larger projects. The shop owner said that some residents who had previously bought replacement products online were now visiting the shop for advice. No figures were collected on the shop's total sales, so the financial effect of the partnership remained uncertain.

F After a year, the organisers considered opening a second location. They decided to postpone expansion until they could recruit enough volunteers to maintain reliable opening hours. They also wanted a better record of what happened to borrowed tools. Low purchase costs had made the original scheme possible, but maintaining the service required continuing attention to staffing, safety and administration. Its future depended on these ordinary tasks as much as on public enthusiasm.

Reading questions one

Questions 1 to 5

Do the following statements agree with the information in the passage? Write **TRUE**, **FALSE** or **NOT GIVEN**.

1. The repair library was created to replace local repair businesses.

2. Members had to complete a safety introduction before borrowing tools.

3. Thursday opening hours were extended after borrowing patterns became clear.

4. Most members borrowed tools every month.

5. Workshop participants completed more successful repairs at home after the programme changed.

Questions 6 to 8

Choose the correct heading for paragraphs D, E and F from the list below. Write **i-v**. Not all headings are used.

i A partnership with benefits but uncertain financial results

ii Why expansion had to wait

iii A shift from watching to doing

iv A decision to allow electrical repairs

v The success of a national advertising campaign

6. Paragraph D

7. Paragraph E

8. Paragraph F

Questions 9 to 12

Complete the sentences. Choose **ONE WORD ONLY** from the passage for each answer.

9. The library did not have the necessary expertise and ____ to supervise electrical repairs.

10. The most popular collection period was Thursday ____.

11. A local shop provided small parts at a ____.

12. The organisers wanted to recruit enough ____ before expanding.

Questions 13 and 14

Choose the correct letter, **A, B, C or D**.

13. Why did the organisers change the workshop format? A Participants wanted longer lectures. B Participants lacked confidence to repeat repairs independently. C The equipment was too expensive. D The shop requested the change.

14. What is the main point of the final paragraph? A Public enthusiasm removes administrative difficulties. B A second location had already opened successfully. C Ongoing practical management is essential to the scheme. D Tool costs were the only obstacle to expansion.

Before checking: note the paragraph supporting each answer. For any Not Given choice, write down exactly which information is missing. Allow no marks for explanations in your raw score; use them to evaluate your reasoning after the attempt.

Reading answers one

Answers with evidence

1 FALSE. A says the organisers did not intend to compete with local repair businesses. Replacing those businesses contradicts that stated intention.

2 TRUE. B says borrowing required a short introduction to safety procedures. Free membership does not remove that condition.

3 TRUE. C describes the unexpectedly busy Thursday collection period, followed by an extension of Thursday opening hours.

4 NOT GIVEN. C says many members borrowed only once, but it does not state what proportion borrowed monthly. “Many” does not establish whether a different group formed a majority. Do not turn an unspecified quantity into “most”.

5 NOT GIVEN. D reports confidence and explicitly notes that successful repairs outside the workshops were not measured. A reported feeling is not evidence of the claimed outcome.

6 iii. D's main development is the switch from demonstration to practical participation. The confidence finding explains the reason and reported benefit.

7 i. E describes discounted materials and possible business benefits, while acknowledging missing sales figures.

8 ii. F explains that staffing and administration needed attention before another location could open.

9 insurance. B pairs expertise with insurance. The one-word limit excludes “the necessary insurance”.

10 evening. C identifies Thursday evening, not the weekend, as the busiest collection period.

11 discount. E gives the exact phrase “at a discount”. The grammar of the question already supplies “a”.

12 volunteers. F says enough volunteers were needed to maintain reliable opening hours. Keep the plural form.

13 B. D says people enjoyed demonstrations but lacked confidence to repeat the procedures. The other reasons are absent.

14 C. F broadens the discussion from the original low costs to the recurring work of running a service. D is too narrow and contradicts the emphasis on staffing.

Learn from the result

Record your score out of 14 without assigning an IELTS band. If items 4 and 5 were difficult, practise separating absent evidence from contradiction. If headings were difficult, summarise each paragraph in eight words or fewer. If completion errors occurred, inspect spelling, plural endings and the limit before doing another passage.

Reading passage two

What a quiet room can tell us

Original teaching passage about a fictional study. Suggested time for this passage and its questions: 18 minutes. The research described here is invented for language practice.

A A university team investigated whether changing the sound environment of a shared study room would affect how students used it. The existing room was neither silent nor especially noisy: students could talk quietly, and occasional group discussions were permitted. The team wanted to know whether clearer rules would change patterns of use. It did not set out to determine a universal ideal level of noise for learning.

B For the first two weeks, the room operated normally. During the next two weeks, signs designated the morning as a silent period and the afternoon as a discussion period. Furniture, lighting and opening hours remained unchanged. A researcher counted occupied seats at fixed times each day. Students could also complete an optional questionnaire about their experience. No individual student was required to attend during either period.

C Morning occupancy increased during the trial, while afternoon occupancy declined slightly. This initially appeared to support the idea that students preferred silence. However, the university's examination timetable created a complication. Several large courses held assessments during the second half of the trial, when students might have been seeking quiet places regardless of the new rules. The team therefore cautioned against attributing the entire change to the signs.

D Questionnaire responses added a different perspective. Some students said the silent mornings helped them read demanding material. Others valued knowing when conversation was acceptable, even if they rarely used the silent period. One respondent explained that uncertainty about disturbing others had previously made group work uncomfortable. Clear expectations, rather than silence itself, may therefore have accounted for part of the positive response.

E The researchers also interviewed library staff. Staff reported fewer disputes about noise, but they had spent time explaining the new arrangement to visitors. This raised a question about scale: a rule that worked in one room might require considerable communication if introduced across an entire building. The team did not calculate the cost of staff time. It recommended that any wider trial record both user experience and the work needed to maintain the arrangement.

F Two researchers interpreted the findings differently. Dr Patel argued that predictable conditions were the most promising feature and proposed testing clearly labelled zones. Dr Reed emphasised the timing problem and wanted a longer trial outside the examination period. They agreed that seat counts alone could not show whether students learned more effectively. A crowded room might reflect convenience, habit or a shortage of alternatives, rather than improved concentration.

G The final report recommended further testing rather than immediate university-wide adoption. It proposed collecting comparable observations at different times of year and asking students what kinds of work they completed in the room. The study's value lay partly in showing how an apparently simple question - whether silence helps - could conceal several different questions about choice, expectations and the interpretation of evidence.

Reading questions two

Questions 1 to 4

Choose **TRUE**, **FALSE** or **NOT GIVEN**.

1. The study aimed to establish the best noise level for every learning situation.

2. The room's furniture was changed during the trial.

3. Students were free to decide whether to use the room.

4. Students who completed the questionnaire achieved higher examination scores.

Questions 5 to 7

Which paragraph contains the following information? Write **A-G**. You may use a letter more than once.

5. A possible explanation involving the timing of examinations.

6. An unmeasured cost associated with implementing the arrangement.

7. A reason why high occupancy may not indicate better learning.

Questions 8 to 10

Match the statements with **A Dr Patel**, **B Dr Reed**, or **C both researchers**. You may use any letter more than once.

8. A new trial should avoid the examination period.

9. Clearly identified areas could be worth testing.

10. Counting occupied seats cannot establish educational improvement.

Questions 11 to 13

Complete the summary. Choose **ONE WORD ONLY** from the passage for each answer.

The room was silent in the 11 ____ and allowed discussion later in the day. Staff noticed fewer 12 ____ about noise. The final report advised further testing instead of immediate university-wide 13 ____.

Questions 14 and 15

Choose the correct letter, **A, B, C or D**.

14. What does paragraph D suggest? A All respondents preferred silence. B Predictable expectations may have helped users. C Group work was forbidden throughout the trial. D Questionnaires proved that learning improved.

15. What is the writer's main purpose? A To argue that all university rooms must be silent. B To show why interpreting a small practical study requires caution. C To prove that questionnaires are useless. D To recommend replacing library staff with signs.

Review prompt: identify at least three distinctions the passage makes: aim versus finding, observation versus cause, and usage versus learning. These distinctions appear frequently in academic argument and are more useful than memorising the topic vocabulary alone.

Reading answers two

1 FALSE. A explicitly rejects the aim of finding a universal ideal noise level. “Every learning situation” overstates the study's purpose.

2 FALSE. B says furniture, lighting and opening hours remained unchanged. The signs and time-based rules were the changes.

3 TRUE. B states that no individual had to attend during either period. Participation in using the room was voluntary.

4 NOT GIVEN. Examination results of questionnaire respondents are not reported. The passage mentions assessments as a possible influence on room use, not as measured outcomes for respondents.

5 C. The examination timetable may partly explain the rise in morning occupancy.

6 E. Staff time was required, but its cost was not calculated. This matches an unmeasured implementation cost.

7 F. Convenience, habit or limited alternatives could make a room crowded without improving concentration.

8 B. Dr Reed wants a longer trial outside the examination period. Keep this separate from Dr Patel's proposed zones.

9 A. Dr Patel proposes clearly labelled zones because predictable conditions seem promising.

10 C. Both agree that seat counts alone do not demonstrate more effective learning.

11 morning. B describes the morning as silent. “Mornings” is not the exact word in that sentence, while “morning” fits the supplied wording.

12 disputes. E reports fewer disputes about noise. “Complaints” might seem plausible but is not the requested passage word.

13 adoption. G contrasts further testing with immediate university-wide adoption.

14 B. D offers clarity about acceptable behaviour as a possible benefit. “May” preserves the uncertainty. D is unsupported because user comments do not prove educational improvement.

15 B. The passage explores alternative explanations, limitations and cautious next steps. It does not conclude that silence is always best.

Extend the learning

Write a two-sentence summary without looking at the passage. Possible answer: “A study room trial changed when silence and discussion were expected. Although some measures and comments were positive, timing effects and limited outcome data prevented a strong conclusion.”

Record your result out of 15. Then explain one wrong option in each multiple-choice question. Being able to reject a tempting alternative for a precise reason is evidence of stronger reading control.

A listening workflow

Prepare your attention

Before a recording begins, read the questions and predict what each answer will look like: a date, a place, a plural noun, an opinion or a letter. Notice what is already supplied. If a form says “Cost: £___”, the answer does not need an additional word such as “pounds” unless the task instructions require it.

IELTS Listening contains four parts of ten questions each. Everyday situations appear first, followed by educational or training contexts. Recordings are played once, and a range of accents can appear. [S2]

Follow meaning as well as words

You may hear an answer, a correction and then confirmation. “We first booked Tuesday, but the room wasn't available, so we're meeting on Thursday.” If the question asks for the final meeting day, Tuesday is a distractor. Keep listening until the decision is clear.

If you miss an answer, use the next question to recover your place. Spending twenty seconds reconstructing one missed word can cause several further losses. Enter the most plausible supported answer during review if you can, but do not stop following the recording.

Review in layers

First, mark your answers without reading the transcript. Replay the difficult section and try again. Then use the transcript to identify what you missed: unfamiliar vocabulary, connected speech, a change of mind or an instruction. Finally, listen once more without the transcript.

This sequence separates hearing from understanding. If a sentence is easy to understand in print but hard to recognise in audio, more vocabulary lists may not fix the issue. Short dictation and repeated listening to the same sound pattern may help.

Daily drill: choose thirty seconds of natural speech. Write what you hear, compare it with a reliable transcript, and mark omitted small words and endings. Replay at normal speed after checking. Use slowed audio as a temporary learning aid, then return to normal speed.

For full exam timing and the computer interface, follow your current official practice test and booking instructions rather than using a generic transfer-time rule from an older resource.

Numbers spelling and exact details

Listen for the final value

Prices, dates, names and addresses require precise attention. A speaker may correct a number or distinguish between two fees: “The standard fee is eighteen pounds, but students pay twelve.” Read the question carefully to determine which category it asks about.

Practise pairs such as thirteen/thirty, fourteen/forty and fifteen/fifty in full phrases. Context often helps: “fifteen seats” and “fifty seats” have different meanings, but neither is impossible. Do not choose solely because one number seems more reasonable.

Spell as a skill

Make a personal list of frequently misspelled words: accommodation, environment, government, restaurant, Wednesday, February, library and necessary. Say the word, cover it, write it, check it and use it in a phrase. Repeated copying while looking is less demanding than recalling the spelling.

For names, practise hearing letters in short groups. Ask a partner to spell fictional names, then read back what you wrote. Keep letters and numbers distinct in codes. When practising with synthetic speech, use natural recordings too, because letter pronunciation and rhythm can differ.

Mini practice

Read these as scripts for a partner. The listener should not see them first.

1. “The appointment was at 4:15, but we've moved it to 4:50.” Question: What is the new time?

2. “The general ticket costs £24. With your student card, it's £16.” Question: What does a student pay?

3. “My surname is Denton: D-E-N-T-O-N.” Question: What is the surname?

4. “Please use the side entrance on Market Road, not the main entrance on King Street.” Question: Which road should visitors use?

Answers: 1. 4:50; 2. £16 / 16 if the currency is supplied; 3. Denton; 4. Market Road.

Checking habit: verify the category, spelling, singular or plural form and word limit. A correctly heard answer can still lose its value if it is entered in the wrong question or with unnecessary words.

Distractors and changing opinions

Track the decision

Academic discussions often include proposals, objections and agreement. The first idea is not necessarily the final plan. Listen for signals such as “initially”, “but”, “actually”, “instead”, “on second thoughts” and “we agreed”. These words indicate relationships, but the surrounding meaning remains essential.

Example: “We could interview visitors at the station.” “That would be convenient, but we'd miss people who drive.” “You're right. Let's use an online questionnaire and advertise it across the town.” Final method: an online questionnaire. The station interview was considered and rejected.

Separate speakers

If asked what one student thinks, do not answer with another speaker's opinion. A short “yes” can acknowledge hearing rather than agree with every detail. Listen to the complete response: “Yes, I see your point, but I'm still concerned about the sample size” expresses reservation.

Practise

Script: “I expected the workshop to be too theoretical,” says Nia. “Actually, the demonstrations were useful. My only complaint is that we didn't have enough time to ask questions.”

Question: What was Nia dissatisfied with? A The lack of practical demonstrations; B The limited discussion time; C The difficult reading materials.

Answer: B. A reflects an initial concern that did not become the final judgement. C is not mentioned.

Script: “Our tutor liked the topic but said the research question was too broad. She didn't ask us to collect more data yet; first, we need to narrow the focus.”

Question: What should the students do next? A Change their subject completely; B Gather more data; C Make their question more specific.

Answer: C. A exaggerates the feedback, and B is explicitly delayed.

Review drill: transcribe a short discussion and label each turn proposal, objection, support, correction or decision. Then listen again without the transcript. This helps you follow the logic instead of treating the recording as a stream of isolated keywords.

Maps directions and positions

Establish your starting point

Before listening, locate the entrance, compass direction and any named landmarks. Distinguish the speaker's route from the page's left and right. “On your left” depends on the direction you are facing; “west of the pond” depends on the map's orientation.

Useful language includes opposite, beside, beyond, at the far end, between, across from, just past and in the northwest corner. Practise each phrase with a simple drawing. “Beyond the bridge” means farther along the route after crossing or passing it; it does not automatically mean north.

A small map drill

Imagine a rectangular garden with north at the top. The entrance is at the middle of the south side. A straight path goes north from the entrance to a fountain. West of the fountain is a café; east is a greenhouse. A playground stands directly north of the greenhouse. A seating area is northwest of the fountain.

Questions: 1 What is east of the fountain? 2 What is north of the greenhouse? 3 Where is the seating area relative to the fountain? 4 If you enter and face north, which side is the café on?

Answers: 1 greenhouse; 2 playground; 3 northwest; 4 left.

Listen for exclusions

“The old café beside the entrance has closed. The new café is opposite the greenhouse.” The first location may remain on the map as a distractor. Follow words such as old, new, moved and replaced to identify the requested feature.

Partner practice: draw a six-place map and give directions without showing its labels. Ask your partner to label a blank copy. Then reverse roles. Check whether misunderstandings came from vocabulary, orientation or missing landmarks.

In an exam task with lettered options, enter the requested letter rather than the name of the place. In a word-completion task, follow the word limit. Accurate spatial understanding and accurate answer format are separate checks; both are necessary.

Notes and lecture structure

Follow the outline

In a lecture-style recording, headings and notes reveal the organisation before you hear the details. Notice whether the speaker is moving through causes, stages, advantages, limitations or examples. Predict the kind of information each gap needs.

Example notes: “Problem: limited ____; solution: shared equipment; unexpected result: stronger ____ between participants.” The first gap may require a resource such as space or funding; the second may require a relationship noun. Prediction helps attention but is not an answer until the recording supports it.

Recognise signposts

“Turning now to…” introduces a new section. “A case in point…” introduces an example. “The main limitation…” signals a weakness. “This does not mean…” prevents an overgeneralisation. These signals help you locate the answer even when the noun itself is familiar.

Watch noun forms and endings. A gap after “several” needs a plural countable noun. A gap after “an” needs a singular noun phrase beginning with a vowel sound. Listen for the exact phrase and then check how it fits the notes.

Mini lecture exercise

Script: “The first trial was limited by a shortage of storage space. Researchers solved this by using smaller containers. This reduced capacity, but it also made the equipment easier to transport. The main remaining difficulty was maintenance, which required trained staff.”

Complete with ONE WORD ONLY: 1 The original problem was insufficient ____ space. 2 Smaller containers made the equipment easier to ____. 3 The remaining challenge was ____.

Answers: 1 storage; 2 transport; 3 maintenance. “Capacity” is a consequence of the change, not the original problem or remaining challenge.

Extension: summarise the lecture in two sentences after answering. This is a learning activity, not an additional test task. If you can fill isolated gaps but cannot explain the sequence, practise following the speaker's organisation. A mental outline helps you recover when an unfamiliar term appears.

Listening mini test

Instructions

Use the four companion audio files in order. Each is a short synthetic-voice drill, not a full IELTS section. Read the relevant questions for thirty seconds, play that part once without pausing, then allow twenty seconds to check. Hide the scripts on pages 44-45. You may also ask a partner to read them naturally once.

Part 1 Booking a workshop

Questions 1-4: Complete the notes using **ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER** for each answer.

1. Participant's surname: ____

2. Workshop day: ____

3. Student fee: £____

4. Bring a ____ to carry the finished item.

Part 2 Visiting a community centre

Questions 5-6: Choose **A, B or C**.

5. Where should visitors register? A Main reception; B Café; C Garden room.

6. Which activity requires advance booking? A Photography talk; B Bicycle workshop; C Garden tour.

Questions 7-8: Write **ONE WORD ONLY** for each answer.

7. The café is opposite the ____.

8. The centre closes at five, but the ____ closes at four.

Part 3 Planning student research

Questions 9-10: Choose **A, B or C**.

9. What topic do the students finally choose? A The price of food; B Library opening hours; C Access to study spaces.

10. What does their tutor want them to do first? A Interview more students; B Narrow the research question; C Write the conclusion.

Questions 11-12: Write **ONE WORD ONLY** for each answer.

11. They will recruit participants using ____ displayed around campus.

12. They will compare responses from two different ____.

Part 4 A talk about seed storage

Questions 13-16: Complete the notes with **ONE WORD ONLY** for each answer.

13. Seeds are first checked for signs of ____.

14. Labels include the collection date and ____.

15. The main risk discussed is excess ____.

16. A sample is tested regularly to check ____.

Record your answers before opening the key. These sixteen items measure your performance on this exercise only; do not use them to calculate a band.

Listening scripts for parts one and two

Part 1 Booking a workshop

Receptionist: Good morning, Riverside Arts. How can I help?

Student: I'd like to book the beginners' pottery workshop. My first name is Maya, and my surname is Denton. That's D, E, N, T, O, N.

Receptionist: Thank you. Were you looking at the Saturday session?

Student: Yes, that's the one I saw advertised.

Receptionist: That session is full, I'm afraid. We have another on Sunday, at ten in the morning.

Student: Sunday works for me. Please book that one.

Receptionist: The normal fee is twenty-four pounds, but do you have a student card?

Student: Yes, I study at the local college.

Receptionist: Then you'll pay sixteen pounds. Bring the card so we can check it. You don't need tools or an apron; those are provided. Please bring a box for the small item you'll make. A bag might not protect it properly.

Student: A box. Fine. Is there anything else?

Receptionist: Arrive ten minutes early. You can pay when you arrive, and water is available in the studio.

Part 2 Visiting a community centre

Welcome to the community centre's open day. Before joining an activity, please register in the garden room. The main reception is being painted, and the café team are only serving refreshments, so neither of those places can register visitors today.

Most activities are open to everyone. You can walk into the photography talk or join the garden tour without reserving a place. The bicycle workshop is different because it has limited equipment. You need to book it in advance at the garden room desk.

For anyone looking for refreshments, the café is opposite the gallery. The old café beside the entrance has become a small shop, so please follow the signs to the new location.

The centre will remain open until five this afternoon. However, the gallery closes at four so staff can prepare a new display. If you want to see the photographs, visit before then. The final garden tour begins at half past three and lasts about twenty minutes. Thank you for coming, and please ask a volunteer if you need directions.

Listening scripts for parts three and four

Part 3 Planning student research

Leo: We need to settle our project topic. I first thought about comparing food prices on campus.

Nina: I considered library opening hours, but another group is already doing that. What about access to study spaces across the university?

Leo: That sounds useful. Let's choose access to study spaces. I spoke to our tutor about it yesterday.

Nina: Did she say we should start interviewing people?

Leo: Not yet. She said our question was too broad. First, we need to narrow it down. We could focus on students who need a place to work between classes.

Nina: Good. How should we find participants? An email might be ignored.

Leo: Let's use posters around campus. We can put a link to our questionnaire on them. We should ask permission before putting anything up.

Nina: Agreed. We also need a useful comparison. Comparing first-year and final-year students could be complicated because their timetables differ so much.

Leo: Then let's compare two departments instead. We can choose departments on opposite sides of campus.

Nina: Fine. I'll draft the questionnaire tonight, and you can check whether the questions match our narrower focus.

Part 4 A talk about seed storage

Today I'll describe the procedure used in our fictional community seed store. This is a simplified example for the listening exercise, rather than technical advice for storing every type of seed.

When a new batch arrives, volunteers first check the seeds for signs of damage. Anything visibly unsuitable is separated from the batch. The remaining seeds are prepared for storage, and the containers are labelled carefully.

Each label includes the collection date and the location. The name of the person who donated the seeds is recorded separately, so it is not part of the container label described here.

A major concern is excess moisture. Even when a container looks secure, unsuitable conditions can affect what is stored inside it. Volunteers therefore monitor the storage area and report any problems promptly.

Finally, keeping seeds is not enough; staff need to know whether they can still grow. A sample from each batch is tested regularly to check germination. The results help the team decide which batches should be replaced. The system depends on careful records as well as suitable storage conditions.

Listening answers and review

1 Denton. The surname is explicitly spelled. Capitalisation is less important for this drill than the correct sequence of letters.

2 Sunday. Saturday is the originally advertised session, but it is full. The student accepts Sunday.

3 16 / sixteen. Twenty-four pounds is the normal price; the student's price is sixteen. The printed question already provides the currency symbol.

4 box. Tools and an apron are provided. A bag is mentioned as unsuitable. The instruction asks for one word.

5 C. Visitors register in the garden room. Main reception and the café are explicitly excluded from registration duties.

6 B. Limited equipment means the bicycle workshop needs booking. The other two activities do not.

7 gallery. The current café is opposite the gallery. The former café location is a distractor.

8 gallery. The building closes at five, but this particular space closes at four. Answer the named exception.

9 C. Food prices and library hours are considered before the students agree on access to study spaces.

10 B. The tutor wants a more specific research question before interviews begin. “Not yet” rules out immediate interviewing.

11 posters. Email is considered but not chosen. Keep the plural because the students plan several posters around campus.

12 departments. Comparing year groups is rejected because of timetable differences. The final comparison is between departments.

13 damage. The opening check concerns visible damage. Do not substitute an unsupported word such as disease.

14 location. The donor's name is recorded elsewhere, not on the label described in the question.

15 moisture. This is the specifically named risk. The answer must be one word.

16 germination. The testing checks whether seeds can still grow. Practise the spelling if you understood the meaning but wrote it incorrectly.

Choose your next drill

For 2, 3, 9 or 12, practise following corrections and final decisions. For 1, 11, 13 or 16, practise spelling and sound recognition. For 5-8, practise locating the exact requested detail. Replay only after recording your first score; then distinguish “correct on first hearing” from “correct after review”. Neither result is an official IELTS band estimate.

Writing with a plan

Solve the communication problem

Task 1 asks you to select and report important visual information. Task 2 asks you to develop a relevant position or response. A well-written answer to a different question does not fulfil the task. Before writing, identify the purpose, required content and boundaries.

For Task 1, inspect the title, units, dates and categories. Select the broad pattern and supporting comparisons. For Task 2, underline the topic, the exact claim and every instruction. Decide your position before drafting so the introduction, body and conclusion fit together.

Use time deliberately

A suggested Task 1 routine is three minutes to analyse and plan, fourteen to write and three to check. A suggested Task 2 routine is five minutes to plan, thirty to write and five to check. Adapt these allocations during practice. They are working methods, not separate exam rules.

Paragraphs should group related content. In a chart report, one paragraph might compare two rising categories while another describes a falling category. In an essay, each body paragraph should develop a reason or response that helps answer the prompt.

Avoid formula dependence

You can learn useful structures, but memorised introductions such as “Since the dawn of civilisation…” rarely help a specific modern question. A direct opening is easier to control: “Some cities are considering free public transport. I support targeted subsidies rather than completely free services.”

Do not invent research statistics to make an essay sound authoritative. A clearly framed hypothetical example can explain a mechanism: “For example, a worker on an early shift may be unable to use a bus service that starts after seven.”

Planning exercise: for “Should universities require all students to complete an internship?”, list two possible benefits, one limitation and your position. Then discard any idea that does not address the word “require”. This small step can prevent an entire essay from becoming a general discussion of work experience.

Describing change in Task 1

Pair verbs and nouns correctly

“Sales rose sharply” uses a verb plus adverb. “There was a sharp rise in sales” uses an adjective plus noun. Both are useful. Avoid “sales had a sharply increase”. Learn the complete patterns rather than mixing their parts.

Useful verbs include rise, increase, grow, fall, decline, fluctuate, recover and remain stable. Choose the verb that matches the data. If values rise in every period, “fluctuate” is wrong. If only the first and final values are given, do not invent the path between them.

Distinguish endpoints and changes

“The figure rose to 80” gives the final value. “It rose by 20” gives the size of the increase. “It rose from 60 to 80” gives both endpoints. If a proportion rises from 20% to 30%, the increase is ten percentage points, or 50% relative to the original value.

Build an overview

An overview identifies the biggest patterns: which categories rose or fell, which was largest, and whether a ranking changed. It should not simply repeat every number. Example: “Overall, cycling became more common, while car use declined; bus travel remained the largest category.” Use this only when all three claims match the chart.

Practise

Data: visits in 2010, 2015 and 2020. Museum A: 100,000; 150,000; 200,000. Museum B: 180,000; 170,000; 160,000.

Write an overview and two comparisons.

Possible answer: “Overall, attendance at Museum A increased, while Museum B experienced a decline. Museum A overtook Museum B by the final year. A's visitor total doubled from 100,000 to 200,000, whereas B's fell by 20,000 over the period.”

Accuracy check: “overtook by 2020” is supported; the precise year of overtaking is not shown. Task 1 rewards faithful description. Do not explain the trends with tourism policy, ticket prices or popularity unless the visual itself supplies that information.

A table report with a worked model

Original practice task

The table shows the percentage of commuters in a fictional city using four main travel modes in 2010 and 2020. Summarise the information, selecting the main features and making relevant comparisons. Write at least 150 words.

Mode	2010	2020
Car	50%	35%
Bus	30%	35%
Bicycle	10%	20%
Walking	10%	10%

Model report

The table compares the proportions of commuters who travelled by car, bus, bicycle and on foot in a city in 2010 and 2020.

Overall, car use became less common, while the shares of bus travel and cycling increased. Cars were the dominant mode at the beginning of the period, but by 2020 they accounted for the same proportion as buses. Walking remained unchanged and was the least common mode in the final year.

In 2010, half of all commuters used cars, compared with 30% who travelled by bus. Over the following decade, the car figure fell by 15 percentage points to 35%. In contrast, the share using buses rose by five points, reaching an identical final level.

Cycling experienced the largest proportional increase, doubling from 10% to 20%. It therefore became twice as common as walking in 2020, whereas the two modes had equal shares in 2010. Together, cycling and walking represented 30% of journeys in the final year, compared with 20% at the start.

Why the report works

The overview selects the main changes and final ranking. The body groups cars with buses, then cycling with walking. “Largest proportional increase” is carefully distinguished from the largest percentage-point change: cycling doubles, while car use falls by fifteen points.

Your turn: rewrite the report with different grouping. Begin the first detail paragraph with the two growing modes. Keep every number and relationship accurate. Avoid adding causes, recommendations or an opinion about which transport mode is best.

Describing a process

Follow stages and transformations

For a process, identify the beginning, endpoint, main stages and any branches or repeated cycles. Use the present simple if no past date is given. Use passive forms when the material matters more than the actor: “The sheets are dried.” Use active forms for natural actions: “Water evaporates.”

Original simplified practice diagram:

Used paper collected > sorted > mixed with water > screened > pressed into sheets > dried > cut and packaged

Task: Summarise the process shown above in at least 150 words. The diagram is a simplified teaching example, not a complete industrial specification.

Model report

The diagram illustrates a seven-stage process for turning used paper into packaged sheets of recycled paper.

Overall, the process begins with the collection of discarded paper and ends with cutting and packaging the finished sheets. Between these points, the material is sorted, combined with water and processed into a form that can be pressed and dried.

At the first stage, used paper is collected and then sorted. Once sorting has been completed, the selected material is mixed with water. This mixture is subsequently screened before it moves on to the stage in which sheets are formed. The diagram therefore places screening between mixing and pressing.

The screened material is pressed into sheets, which are then dried. Drying is the final stage before the paper is cut and packaged. The sequence is shown as a single series of steps, with no alternative route or return to an earlier stage indicated. Packaging completes the process presented in the diagram.

Language to reuse

“Once X has been completed, Y…” links stages. “Before being dried” avoids repeating the subject. “The process begins with…” identifies the boundary. Do not add chemicals, machinery or temperatures that are absent from the visual.

Practice: change three passive sentences to active sentences using “workers” or “the system”. Decide which version keeps the focus more naturally on the material. Grammatical variety should support the description rather than distract from the sequence.

Describing maps and changes to places

Group changes spatially

In a map comparison, identify what was added, removed, relocated or left unchanged. Establish orientation from the visual. If no compass is shown, use relative descriptions such as “beside the entrance” rather than inventing north and south.

Original text map for practice: Both maps have north at the top. In 2000, a park contained a pond in the northwest, tennis courts in the northeast, a central lawn and a car park in the southeast. The entrance was on the south boundary. In 2025, the pond, lawn and entrance remained. A café replaced the tennis courts, and a playground replaced the car park. A new path connected the entrance with the café, passing along the eastern side of the lawn.

Model report

The two park plans show changes between 2000 and 2025. Overall, the park gained a café and a playground, while the pond, central lawn and southern entrance remained in their original positions. A new path also improved the connection between the entrance and the northeastern part of the park.

In 2000, the tennis courts occupied the northeast corner. By 2025, these had been replaced by a café on the same site. A path was added from the entrance on the south boundary to this new facility, running along the eastern side of the central lawn.

The other main change occurred in the southeast, where the original car park was removed and a playground was created in its place. In contrast, the pond in the northwest was retained, as was the lawn in the middle of the park. The location of the entrance did not change during the period shown, and the plans indicate no additional entrance on any other boundary.

Check the relationship

“A café replaced the courts” means the café is new. “The café was replaced by courts” reverses the meaning. Practise both active and passive versions carefully.

Your turn: describe the southeast change in two ways, then write one sentence grouping the unchanged features. Do not claim that total park area increased; the information does not establish that.

Understanding essay questions

Separate topic from instruction

Topic: university education. Specific claim: universities should teach only job-related skills. Instruction: to what extent do you agree or disagree? An essay about the general importance of education misses the central restriction “only”. Circle limiting words such as all, only, mainly, more and should.

For an opinion question, establish your degree of agreement and support it consistently. For a discussion question, explain both views and give your own opinion when requested. For advantages and disadvantages, identify both; if asked whether one outweighs the other, make a comparative judgement. For two direct questions, answer both explicitly.

Four prompt examples

Opinion: “Universities should provide all course materials online instead of using printed books. To what extent do you agree or disagree?” Consider the absolute replacement, not simply whether online resources are useful.

Discussion: “Some people believe students learn best independently, while others favour group learning. Discuss both views and give your opinion.” Explain why each approach can help, then state your view.

Evaluation: “More employees work from home. Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?” Weigh the significance of the effects, not just the number of points on each side.

Two questions: “Many cities struggle to provide affordable housing. Why is this happening, and what could be done?” Link realistic solutions to the causes you identify.

Build a position before a paragraph plan

For the online-materials prompt, a workable position is: “Digital materials should be widely available, but printed options should remain for students who need them.” This permits a paragraph on access and convenience and another on the limitations of complete replacement.

Practice: choose one prompt and write a one-sentence position. Then write the purpose of each body paragraph. Check that together they fulfil every instruction. If the question asks for an opinion, “This essay will discuss both sides” is a plan announcement, not a position. State what you actually think, and make the body justify it.

Developing a paragraph

Explain how the claim works

A useful body paragraph begins with a relevant point, explains the mechanism, illustrates it and connects it to the essay's argument. This is a flexible reasoning sequence, not a rule requiring exactly four sentences.

Weak paragraph: “Public libraries are important. They have many books. People like books. Governments should support them.” The ideas are related, but the paragraph does not explain why public funding is justified.

Developed paragraph: “Public libraries can reduce barriers to independent learning. People who cannot afford specialist books or a quiet workspace can use shared resources without purchasing them individually. For example, a student preparing for a professional exam may rely on library reference materials and evening study space. Funding these services therefore supports access to learning beyond formal education.”

Check the example's job

The example should illustrate the mechanism, not introduce a new topic. If the paragraph concerns affordable access, a long story about the architecture of a library is distracting. A brief hypothetical example is enough when it makes the reasoning concrete.

Avoid pretending that invented figures are research findings. “A student may…” clearly presents a possibility. “A study proved that 87%…” suggests evidence you must actually have. IELTS essays do not require fabricated statistics.

Add depth instead of extra points

Start: “Flexible work helps parents.” Ask how: it may make school collections easier. Ask under what condition: the job must permit flexible hours. Ask about a limitation: unpredictable meetings could reduce the benefit. Now you have a reasoned paragraph rather than a list of claims.

Your turn: develop “Cities should improve bus reliability” into a paragraph. Include a mechanism, an example and a limitation or condition. A possible route is: predictable arrival times reduce the risk of lateness; a shift worker can plan a commute; reliability must improve alongside reasonable coverage.

Revision test: label each sentence's role. If two sentences repeat the same point, combine them. If a sentence has no role in supporting the topic sentence, remove it or move it to a more relevant paragraph.

An opinion essay with commentary

Original Task 2 prompt

Universities should require every student to complete a work placement before graduating. To what extent do you agree or disagree? Write at least 250 words.

Model essay

Work placements can help students connect academic study with professional life. However, I disagree that they should be compulsory for every university student. Universities should make good placements widely available while allowing suitable alternatives when a placement would create practical difficulties or offer little educational value.

The main argument for a placement is that it exposes students to the everyday demands of employment. A student may understand a subject well but have limited experience of meeting deadlines, communicating with clients or working within a team. A carefully supervised placement can develop these abilities in a realistic setting. It can also help students decide whether a particular career suits them before they commit to it. These benefits explain why universities should invest in strong relationships with employers.

Nevertheless, making placements universal could create unfair barriers. Some students support themselves through paid work or have caring responsibilities, and a distant or unpaid placement may be difficult to manage. In addition, the educational value of placements varies. A student who spends several weeks performing routine tasks without guidance may learn less than one who completes a demanding research or community project. Requiring participation alone does not guarantee a worthwhile experience.

A more flexible policy would preserve the benefits while addressing these problems. Universities could offer placements, supervised projects and other practical options that meet clear learning goals. Financial support and transparent quality standards would also help more students participate. The important requirement should be meaningful practical learning, rather than one identical route for everyone.

In conclusion, work placements are valuable when they are accessible and well designed, but a universal requirement is too rigid. Universities should provide several credible ways for students to apply their knowledge before graduation.

Study the choices

The position responds to “every” and “require”. The first body paragraph acknowledges value; the next explains objections; the third offers an alternative consistent with the position. “Can”, “may” and “could” reflect conditional effects. This is a teaching model, not an examiner-scored script.

A discussion essay with commentary

Original Task 2 prompt

Some people believe public libraries should focus on printed books, while others think they should prioritise digital services. Discuss both views and give your own opinion. Write at least 250 words.

Model essay

Public libraries must decide how to divide limited resources between printed collections and digital services. Printed books remain valuable for readers who prefer them or lack suitable technology, while digital provision can extend access beyond the library building. In my view, libraries should maintain a strong core collection and expand digital services according to local needs.

Those who favour printed books emphasise accessibility and the quality of the reading experience. A borrowed book requires no personal device, account or reliable internet connection. This matters for residents who would otherwise struggle to obtain reading materials. Some readers also find it easier to concentrate on a long text when using paper. For these users, reducing printed collections too sharply could make the library less useful, even if the digital catalogue became larger.

Supporters of digital services point to their flexibility. People who work during normal opening hours may be able to borrow an electronic book from home, while students can search online reference materials quickly. Libraries can also provide computers and guidance for residents completing applications or developing digital skills. These services respond to practical needs that a collection of printed books cannot meet by itself.

I believe the most effective approach is to combine these functions rather than impose the same balance everywhere. A library serving many residents without internet access may need both computer facilities and a substantial printed collection. Another branch might face stronger demand for remote borrowing. Decisions should therefore consider actual use, barriers to access and the needs of people who currently use the library least.

In conclusion, both printed books and digital services serve important purposes. Libraries should preserve access to print while developing digital provision in a way that reflects their communities, rather than treating one format as a complete replacement for the other.

Study the choices

Each view receives a reasoned explanation. The opinion appears in the introduction and develops in the final body paragraph. The conclusion maintains the same position. “Digital services” is defined through examples, which prevents it from remaining an empty label.

Problems solutions and evaluation

Connect the remedy to the cause

Prompt: “Many employees spend long periods travelling to work. What problems does this cause, and what measures could reduce them?” A response should identify consequences of commuting and measures that address those consequences or the commute itself. A paragraph about why people enjoy travelling would not answer the prompt.

Plan: problem one is reduced time for rest or family; problem two is unreliable arrival times. Measures include flexible schedules where jobs allow them and more reliable transport on busy routes. Explain who can act and why the action would help.

A worked body paragraph

“Long and unpredictable journeys can make daily life difficult to organise. An employee who cannot estimate the journey home may struggle to arrange childcare or attend evening classes. Employers could reduce this pressure by offering flexible start and finish times where the work permits it. This would allow some staff to avoid the busiest period, although it would be less practical in jobs that require fixed shift coverage.”

The proposal is specific, linked to the problem and qualified. It does not claim that flexible hours solve every transport issue.

Weigh advantages and disadvantages

For an “outweigh” question, compare importance, reach, duration and the possibility of reducing harm. Three minor benefits do not necessarily outweigh one major disadvantage. A useful judgement might be: “The benefits are greater because they affect most users daily, while the principal drawback can be reduced through targeted support.” Your body must explain those claims.

Practise

Prompt: “More university courses are delivered online. Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?” Write a balanced plan with a clear judgement. Consider flexibility, participation, practical subjects and access to equipment.

Possible position: online delivery offers substantial benefits for suitable courses, but fully replacing in-person teaching would create disadvantages for practical learning and students with limited support. If you choose this position, make clear whether you are evaluating increased online provision or total replacement; the original prompt asks about the former. Do not quietly change the question into an easier one.

Revising an essay in layers

Start with meaning

Original paragraph: “Nowadays technology is very important. Every student must study online because it is cheap. Online classes are good and they improve education. For example, technology is everywhere. Therefore, books are useless.”

The paragraph has several problems: it overgeneralises, provides no mechanism for improvement, uses an irrelevant example and jumps from online classes to the claim that books are useless.

Revised paragraph: “Online classes can make some courses more accessible by reducing the need to travel. A student living far from a university may be able to attend a lecture from home, saving both time and transport costs. However, this benefit depends on reliable internet and suitable equipment. Online provision should therefore expand access while preserving alternatives for students who cannot use it effectively.”

The revision is stronger because the reasoning is specific and its limits are clear. No rare vocabulary is required to make the improvement.

Four editing passes

Task: does every paragraph help answer the exact question? Remove attractive but irrelevant material.

Logic: does each claim have an explanation? Do examples support the claim? Does the conclusion match the position developed earlier?

Language: check verb forms, articles, agreement, prepositions and sentence boundaries. Pay particular attention to errors in your personal log.

Precision: replace vague words where a specific word helps. Keep ordinary words when they already express the meaning accurately. Repetition is sometimes clearer than a misleading synonym.

Your turn

Improve: “The government should make more facilities. This is very beneficial for people. People will become good and society will improve.”

Possible direction: identify the facility, the users and the mechanism. “The council should provide more evening study spaces. These would give students in crowded homes a quiet place to work after school.” Add a reasoned example if the paragraph needs further development.

Timing lesson: major idea changes are easier during planning than in the final minute. Under exam conditions, prioritise clear meaning and recurring errors. During untimed practice, revise deeply so your next first draft improves.

A flexible sentence bank

Use patterns with a purpose

These patterns express relationships. Replace the bracketed content with your own ideas and check that the grammar still works. Do not insert them simply to display variety.

Giving a reason: “One reason for [noun phrase] is that [clause].” Example: “One reason for low attendance is that the venue is difficult to reach.”

Explaining a result: “[Action] can reduce [problem] by [verb + ing].” Example: “Flexible hours can reduce pressure by allowing staff to avoid peak travel times.”

Qualifying a claim: “This may be effective when [condition], but it is less suitable for [group or situation].”

Comparing: “Whereas [group A] tends to [verb], [group B] may [verb].” Example: “Whereas experienced learners may study independently, beginners may need more guidance.”

Conceding: “Although [opposing point], [your main point].” Example: “Although the service is costly, it provides access that some residents would otherwise lack.”

Defining a benefit: “The main advantage is not simply [X], but [more precise Y].” Use this only when the distinction advances the argument.

Reporting data: “[Category A] accounted for [figure], compared with [figure] for [category B].” Check that the units match.

Describing a process: “After being [past participle], the material is [past participle].” The implied subject of both actions must be the same material.

Speaking about change: “I used to [past habit], but these days I [present habit].”

Speaking about significance: “What made it memorable was [noun phrase or clause].” Example: “What made it memorable was how patiently she explained everything.”

Build your own bank

Select three patterns and use each for two different topics. Then write a short paragraph without looking at the patterns. Check that the connectors represent genuine relationships: “therefore” requires a consequence; “however” requires a contrast. A sentence bank should make your thinking easier to express, not decide your thinking for you.

Writing practice exam

Complete both tasks in 60 minutes

Use the format you are preparing to take. Do not consult models, dictionaries or grammar tools during the attempt. These are original practice prompts. They reproduce the two-task structure, but they are not official IELTS questions and do not produce an official score.

Task 1

The table shows the percentage of first-year students at a fictional university choosing three types of accommodation in 2015 and 2025.

Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant. Write **at least 150 words**. Suggested time: 20 minutes.

Accommodation	2015	2025
University residence	45%	35%
Shared rented housing	30%	45%
Living with family	25%	20%

Task 2

Some people believe that universities should make attendance at all lectures compulsory. Others think students should be free to decide which lectures to attend.

Discuss both views and give your own opinion. Write **at least 250 words**. Suggested time: 40 minutes. Give reasons and relevant examples.

Review after the timer ends

Task 1: a suitable overview identifies shared housing as the new largest category, an increase in shared renting, and decreases in the other two categories. University residence falls by ten percentage points; family accommodation falls by five; shared renting rises by fifteen. The table supplies no reasons for these changes.

Task 2: explain the case for attendance, such as structure and participation, and the case for choice, such as independence or competing responsibilities. Give your judgement. You may support one side or a conditional policy, provided the position is clear and developed.

Use pages 49 and 55 as structural comparisons, not as answers to these different questions. Write a corrected version the next day, then attempt a new prompt later in the week. Do not mistake improvement from remembering an essay for flexible performance on an unfamiliar task.

Speaking practice test two

A fresh interview

Use this interview after reviewing test one. Record it under similar conditions so you can compare the organisation and clarity of new answers. The topics overlap with common learning themes, but none is a prediction of an upcoming exam.

Part 1

Technology: What device do you use most often? What do you use it for? Have your habits changed in recent years? Is there a device you would like to learn to use better?

Outdoor places: Do you spend much time outdoors? What outdoor place do you visit most often? Did you enjoy outdoor activities as a child?

Planning: Do you usually plan your day? What happens when your plans change? Do you prefer planning alone or with other people?

Part 2

Describe a time when you solved a problem with another person.

Say what the problem was, who helped you, what you did together, and explain what you learned from the experience.

Prepare for one minute and speak for up to two minutes. Possible follow-up: Would you ask that person for help again?

Part 3

Why do some people hesitate to ask for help? What makes a team effective at solving problems? Should schools teach problem-solving explicitly? Can technology make people too dependent on immediate answers? Is experience always more useful than a new perspective?

A development example

For the final question, a useful opening is: “Experience helps people recognise familiar patterns, but a new perspective can challenge assumptions.” Develop one side, illustrate the other and give a judgement. Avoid simply saying “both are important” and stopping there.

Compare your recordings

Can you sustain Part 2 without repeating the same event? Does Part 3 include explanations rather than only opinions? Are you using accurate past forms in narratives and appropriate modal verbs in predictions? Which pronunciation difficulty still affects understanding?

Choose one answer and transcribe it exactly, including pauses and repairs. Highlight a successful phrase as well as errors. A useful review identifies what to keep, not just what to remove.

Grammar progress test

Work without notes

Allow about twenty minutes. Complete or correct each item. Several rewrites can be valid if they preserve the intended meaning. Answers and explanations are on the next page.

1. She ____ at this university since 2023. [study]

2. The number of international students ____ increasing. [be]

3. Each participant ____ a short questionnaire. [complete, present simple]

4. Correct: “The tutor gave me several useful advices.”

5. Correct: “Although the course is difficult, but I enjoy it.”

6. Complete: “If the service becomes cheaper, more people ____ use it.” [possible result]

7. Correct: “The council should to provide better buses.”

8. Complete: “I am interested in ____ abroad.” [study]

9. Correct: “The bridge was build in 1995.”

10. Join: “The students arrived late. They missed the introduction.” [Use a defining relative clause to identify which students missed it]

11. Correct: “There are less cars in the centre now.”

12. Complete: “The figure rose ____ 40 to 60.”

13. Complete: “The figure rose ____ 20.” [size of increase]

14. Correct: “The policy is popular, it is expensive.”

15. Choose: “I bought a / an university textbook.”

16. Correct: “Education helps the people develop skills.” [People in general]

17. Complete: “By the time I arrived, the lecture ____.” [start]

18. Correct: “The city has changed it's transport policy.”

19. Rewrite: “Workers sort the bottles.” [Focus on bottles]

20. Complete: “The museum, ____ opened in 2010, attracts many visitors.”

Transfer tasks

21. Write one sentence about a past habit and a present habit using “used to” and “but”.

22. Write a conditional recommendation about online learning.

23. Compare a 40% share with a 20% share accurately in two ways.

24. Write two connected sentences explaining a benefit of feedback.

Marking: give one point for each of 1-20 if the grammar and intended meaning are correct. For 21-24, use the examples as guidance and judge accuracy, relevance and clarity. The result is a grammar-learning check, not an IELTS band or a complete assessment of writing ability.

Grammar answers and explanations

1 has studied / has been studying. Both connect a continuing situation with “since 2023”. **2 is.** The subject is “the number”. **3 completes.** “Each participant” is singular.

4 The tutor gave me several useful pieces of advice. “Advice” is uncountable. “Some useful advice” is also correct. **5 Although the course is difficult, I enjoy it.** Remove the second contrast connector.

6 may / might / could. These express a possible result. “Will” is grammatically possible but states a stronger prediction. **7 The council should provide better buses.** Use the base verb after a modal. **8 studying.** The preposition “in” takes an -ing form here.

9 The bridge was built in 1995. The passive needs the past participle. **10 The students who arrived late missed the introduction.** The relative clause identifies the group. **11 There are fewer cars in the centre now.** “Cars” is countable and plural.

12 from. “From…to…” marks endpoints. **13 by.** “By” introduces the amount of change. **14 The policy is popular, but it is expensive.** A full stop or semicolon also repairs the comma splice. **15 a.** “University” begins with a consonant sound.

16 Education helps people develop skills. No article is needed for people in general. **17 had started.** This places the start before arrival. **18 The city has changed its transport policy.** Possessive “its” has no apostrophe.

19 The bottles are sorted. Match the present tense and plural subject. **20 which.** This non-defining relative clause adds information and is separated by commas.

Possible transfer answers

21: “I used to study late at night, but I now work in the morning.” **22:** “If universities expand online learning, they should provide technical support.” **23:** “The first share was twice the second.” / “The difference was twenty percentage points.” **24:** “Clear feedback helps learners identify repeated mistakes. They can then practise the specific patterns they need to improve.”

Group your errors by topic. Revisit the relevant foundation page, write two new examples and repeat only the difficult patterns after several days. Memorising the answer order will not test whether the grammar has become usable.

Official practice and useful books

Begin with reliable free resources

IELTS Academic sample tasks [S10]: use the official tasks to learn question formats and practise with authentic instructions. Select Listening audio and Reading tasks before looking at their answers. Use Writing samples to compare the demands of the two tasks.

British Council IELTS Ready [S11]: the preparation platform offers free and booking-related options. Check the current package details rather than assuming every resource is included in every account. Use it for a structured practice routine and current familiarisation activities.

Official Writing and Speaking descriptors [S7, S9]: read the criteria alongside your own work. Choose one observable target per week, such as developing support or improving paraphrase. Do not use a single attractive sentence as proof of a complete band level.

Two complementary book choices

Cambridge IELTS 20 Academic with Answers and digital materials [S12] contains four authentic practice papers. It is one verified option in the Cambridge practice series, not a claim that it is the newest edition available. Check that the edition is Academic and includes the answers and audio access you need.

English Grammar in Use, Fifth Edition, with answers [S13] is designed for intermediate self-study. Use its units to address errors from your writing and speaking rather than reading it straight through without applying the grammar.

Buying many books is less useful than fully reviewing a small set. Reserve at least one unused authentic test for a later readiness check. Repeating a familiar test can measure memory as well as skill.

A full mock routine

Use one complete official Academic test set. Follow its Listening procedure, then allow 60 minutes for Reading and 60 for Writing. Run Speaking separately with a partner using the stated format. Record materials used, conditions, raw scores and uncertain answers. Ask for descriptor-based feedback on the productive skills.

The URLs for these resources are on page 66 and are also available in the companion hub. For pronunciation and general English, use a reputable learner's dictionary with audio and natural listening material with reliable transcripts; these supplement rather than replace exam-format practice.

Exam readiness and the final week

Look for repeatable performance

Readiness is better judged from several unfamiliar tasks than from your best score on one familiar test. Compare recent official Listening and Reading attempts under consistent conditions. For Writing and Speaking, look for recurring feedback and whether your corrections appear in new work.

If the target is overall Band 7, still check every required component minimum. A university or professional body may require a particular Writing score even if the overall average is sufficient. Requirements belong to the receiving organisation, so confirm them directly.

Practical checklist

Check the test location, arrival instructions, accepted identification and the name on your booking. Read the centre's current rules about belongings and equipment. If you need an access arrangement, contact the provider in advance rather than assuming it can be organised on the day.

Practise typing or the available Writing on Paper option that matches your booking. Use current official familiarisation materials. Confirm local delivery details because the 2026 transition is market-dependent. [S8]

A calm final study sequence

Several days before the test, review your error log and complete one manageable timed task. Identify a few reminders: answer every part of the essay prompt, keep Reading evidence separate from assumptions, and continue listening after a correction.

On the final day, avoid filling your head with dozens of new idioms. Review familiar phrases, organise your documents and protect time for rest. A late marathon of new material is unlikely to repair a long-standing weakness.

During each skill

Listening: recover quickly if you miss one answer. Reading: follow the word limit and move on when stuck. Writing: preserve time for Task 2 and check your exact position. Speaking: respond naturally, develop the point and recover briefly from errors.

Your personal reminder card: write one sentence for each skill based on your own evidence. For example, “Not Given means the necessary information is absent.” Keep the card short enough to remember; a long checklist can become another burden under pressure.

Progress records that guide your next step

Weekly review

Use the following record in a notebook. Complete it after reviewing your work, not immediately after seeing a score.

Week and dates: ____

Materials attempted: ____

Listening result and main error type: ____

Reading result and main error type: ____

Writing task and one change to practise: ____

Speaking recording and one change to practise: ____

Evidence of improvement: ____

Next week's two priorities: ____

An example error entry

Original: “The amount of students increased.” Correction: “The number of students increased.” Explanation: students are countable. New example: “The number of evening classes doubled.” Retest: describe a different table three days later and check the noun phrase.

An example Reading entry might be: “I selected True because the statement sounded plausible. The passage mentioned attendance, but did not compare age groups. Next action: practise identifying the missing comparison.”

A useful weekly review conversation

Ask yourself: What did I attempt without help? What could I explain after checking? What can I now do on a different task? Which error still appears despite repeated review? The final question may identify a need for simpler practice or external feedback.

Do not measure progress only by study hours. Record completed learning cycles: attempt, review, correction and transfer. Thirty minutes spent understanding a recurring error can be more useful than another full test taken without review.

When to adjust the plan

If accuracy improves but time remains a problem, shorten timed drills gradually. If timing is good but errors persist, return to untimed close analysis. If Writing or Speaking seems unchanged, request feedback on a small sample with one clear question, such as “Where does my explanation become hard to follow?”

The goal of tracking is to make the next action obvious. Keep the system simple enough that you spend most of your time practising English rather than managing your records.

Sources and further study

Official information checked on 6 October 2026. Links may change; use the provider's current guidance for your booking. The teaching explanations, fictional passages and uncredited model responses in this book are original instructional material.

S1 IELTS Academic overview - format and shared skills.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test

S2 Listening format - parts, question rules and recordings.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test/ielts-academic-format-listening

S3 Academic Reading format - timing, questions and answer rules.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test/ielts-academic-format-reading

S4 Academic Writing format - task requirements and weighting.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test/ielts-academic-format-writing

S5 Speaking format - interview stages and timing.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/test-types/ielts-academic-test/ielts-academic-format-speaking

S6 Scoring in detail - criteria, rounding and raw-score guidance.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/your-results/ielts-scoring-in-detail

S7 Speaking descriptors - full public assessment criteria.

https://ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-speaking-band-descriptors.pdf

S8 Delivery update - announcement dated 5 March 2026.

https://ielts.org/news-and-insights/updates-to-ielts-test-delivery

S9 Writing descriptors - full public assessment criteria.

https://ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-band-descriptors.pdf

S10 Official Academic sample tasks - questions and practice materials.

https://ielts.org/take-a-test/preparation-resources/sample-test-questions/academic-test

S11 British Council IELTS Ready - preparation platform.

https://takeielts.britishcouncil.org/prepare/ielts-ready

S12 Cambridge IELTS 20 Academic - authentic practice book.

https://shop.cambridge.org/english/product/2700250101

S13 English Grammar in Use Fifth Edition - intermediate grammar study.

https://www.cambridge.es/en/catalogue/grammar-vocabulary-and-pronunciation/grammar/english-grammar-in-use5

Using your three source PDFs

A source guided extension

The following pages turn selected material from your supplied files into practical study activities. Page numbers here refer to PDF page positions, which may differ from printed page numbers. These files are useful study inputs, but their titles and score claims are not proof of official status or examiner validation.

U1: 50 Synonyms That Actually Boost Your Score, 50 PDF pages. Its early guidance encourages contextual practice and avoiding forced vocabulary. Its word families, including people, important, develop, technology and effective, informed the precision workshop on page 68. Selected substitutions need caution because their meanings, grammar or normal word partners differ.

U2: 2025 July - dec question bank (3), 210 PDF pages. The inspected material includes Reading passages, question sets and Writing models. The honeybee passage and questions on PDF pages 4-5 provide an opportunity to practise evidence checking. Treat dates and month labels as organisation within the file, not authentication of past exam content or a forecast of future questions. The file's entire answer bank has not been independently validated.

U3: IELTS Speaking CueCard Answers 50 Polished by claude, 31 PDF pages. The numbered cue cards provide themes such as a special cake, an electronic-device problem, a language learner, a group task and helping someone. These themes inform pages 69-70. Some answers repeat idioms or include broad factual claims. Use the themes and structure as practice prompts, then create your own accurate content.

Use each source for the right job

Use U1 to compare meanings and practise collocations. Use U2 to locate textual evidence and inspect answer quality. Use U3 to practise flexible storytelling and follow-up discussion. For official format and assessment, return to S1-S10.

The original PDFs are not reproduced in the website. The hub uses adapted teaching activities and original examples, with these sources acknowledged. Personal, medical and biographical details inside sample answers should not be assumed to describe you.

A vocabulary precision workshop

Improve meaning rather than word difficulty

Adapted critically from U1, especially PDF pages 6-18 and 24. The replacements below are examples to evaluate, not a universal synonym list.

People > residents, students, employees or citizens. Choose the group you mean. “Residents need safer crossings” includes people who live there; “citizens” introduces a nationality or civic-status meaning that may not fit. “Individuals” is not automatically better than “people”.

Important > essential or useful. “Essential” means necessary, so it strengthens the claim. “A passport is essential for this journey” differs from “A phrasebook is useful”. Do not turn every helpful factor into an indispensable one.

Develop > establish or improve. Establish a programme, develop a skill, improve a service. U1's “cultivate…sources of energy” is less natural than “develop renewable energy sources”. “Cultivate” fits “an interest” or “a habit” more comfortably here.

Technology > digital tools. “Digital tools” works when the discussion concerns software or electronic resources; it does not cover every kind of technology. “Technological progress” describes change, not a device. “The advancement of innovation” is usually less direct than “innovation” or “technological progress”.

Effective > productive. An effective policy achieves its intended result. A productive meeting produces useful work or decisions. “A productive deterrent” is an awkward replacement for “an effective deterrent”. Learn the collocation rather than substituting mechanically.

Global > international. Global suggests worldwide scope. International involves more than one country and need not involve the whole world. “Universal” is stronger still and should not casually replace either.

Practice and answers

Choose the more precise expression: 1 university pupils / university students; 2 develop practical skills / establish practical skills; 3 an effective solution / a productive solution; 4 international cooperation / universal cooperation, when three countries work together.

Preferred answers: students; develop practical skills; effective solution; international cooperation. There is no fixed quota of rare words or idioms that earns Band 7. The official criteria concern range, precision and appropriate use in a complete performance. [S7, S9]

Turn cue card answers into your own speech

Keep the story and simplify the performance

U3's device-problem answers, cards 4 and 6 on PDF pages 3-5, use a laptop failure near a deadline. The underlying sequence is useful: urgent situation, unexpected problem, help, recovery and changed behaviour. You can practise this sequence without repeating every idiom or borrowing someone else's personal history.

An adapted model opening

“I'd like to describe a problem I had while finishing a college presentation. My laptop stopped responding the evening before the deadline, and I was worried that I had lost my work. A friend helped me check the files, and we eventually recovered an earlier version. I still had to redo the final slides, but I submitted the presentation on time. Since then, I've saved a backup copy whenever I work on an important project.”

This short model needs further detail for a full long turn. Add what you tried first, why the friend could help and how your routine changed. The language is deliberately direct: one accurate description of worry is enough; several dramatic idioms can make an ordinary incident sound rehearsed.

Adapt by changing the focus

For “a person who helped you”, describe the friend's behaviour and why it mattered. For “a problem with a device”, explain the failure and solution. For “something you learned”, focus on the new backup habit. Reuse an experience only when it genuinely fits the card; answer its particular question.

A second source theme

U3's special-cake card, PDF page 2, connects a gift with friendship. Practise the same emotional logic using a gift or helpful act from your own experience. Explain why the thought mattered, not merely what the object looked like.

Exercise: make seven-word notes for each theme, then speak without reading the model. Remove any phrase you would not comfortably use in conversation. If a source answer includes a medical, scientific, celebrity or “world's longest” claim, use a simpler personal observation unless you have verified it. IELTS Speaking practice does not require impressive factual claims.

Practise critically with the question bank

A close reading example from U2

On PDF pages 4-5, the honeybee passage describes changing worker roles and offers summary-completion questions. Use it to practise finding exact evidence, while remembering that this is an unverified practice source.

The passage gives the sequence cleaning nursery cells, feeding larvae, construction and foraging. First, draw this sequence from memory. Then check the passage and attach one supporting phrase to each stage. This is a reading-structure activity; it does not require you to verify every biological statement to answer a passage-based question.

Notice a problematic gap

Question 8 reads in part “begins her life with the task of ____ to ensure they are ready for new eggs”, with a limit of no more than two words. The supplied key offers “cleaning / cleaning cells”. However, “they” lacks a clear referent if the answer is only “cleaning”, and the passage uses the longer phrase “cleaning the nursery cells”. Treat this as an imperfect practice item rather than learning a habit of ignoring grammar or word limits.

A clearer rewritten task is: “A young worker cleans the ____ before new eggs arrive.” With NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS from the passage, **nursery cells** fits both grammar and the word limit. This rewrite is an original correction exercise, not an official answer amendment.

A source based weekly circuit

Day 1: choose five U1 vocabulary items and check their meanings and normal partners. Day 2: complete one U2 reading set, writing the evidence beside each answer. Day 3: select a U3 cue card and record an unrehearsed response. Day 4: revise three sentences from that transcript. Day 5: use the same language skills on new topics from this book.

At the weekend, use official material for a more reliable exam-format check. Keep separate records for official tests and informal practice. A high score on a familiar or flawed set should not be treated as a dependable prediction of your test-day result.

Final study principle: trust an explanation because its evidence, meaning and grammar hold together. A polished PDF title, a confident score claim or an answer key should never replace that check.